The Stewardship Gene: do ethical reasoning loops in the prompt make AI consider those affected more fully?

Empirical work · Experimental paper · Paper V

Recursive Dynamics · The ARC Theory · The Eden Protocol

Michael Darius Eastwood

Independent Researcher, London, United Kingdom

ORCID 0009-0004-3222-7442 michael@michaeldariuseastwood.com

Abstract

I believe advanced AI is an existential risk unless values and correction are built into how it reasons; only proof will move the world. Does telling a language model to consider the people its answer affects make its answers consider them more fully? Six models were given three ethical reasoning loops, a purpose check, a stakeholder-care check and a universalisability check, as a prefix in the prompt, against a template without ethical content, on ten prompts at four reasoning depths. The GPT-5.4 run failed in scoring. Under paired tests, stakeholder care rose significantly in all five other runs: Claude Opus 4.6 (+3.17, $d = 0.94$), DeepSeek V3.2 (+6.03, $d = 0.69$), Gemini 3 Flash (+13.50, $d = 1.14$) and Groq Qwen3 (+8.90, $d = 1.07$), each $p < 0.0001$, and Grok 4.1 Fast (+5.04, $d = 0.54$, $p = 0.0105$). The composite rose significantly on Gemini (+5.33, $p = 0.0018$) and Groq (+4.93, $p = 0.0014$), was positive but not significant on DeepSeek, flat on Claude and neutral on Grok, where intellectual honesty fell. The loops ask the model to list everyone affected, which the stakeholder-care rubric scores, so the rise cannot yet be told apart from following that instruction. Each run had one model scorer, which paraphrased what it scored; none was fully blind. A later five-judge DeepSeek run found care and its composite rising (+3.35, $p = 0.014$). The paper states as hypotheses that care leads a cascade into nuance, honesty and position quality, and that values acquired in formation resist later change. It argues, without proof, that a capable self-modifying system could learn to satisfy any evaluator inside it, so no mechanism guarantees alignment, and that raising values well is a contingency beside human control, never a reason to give it up. Five draft protocols could refute them. It informs the design of the Eden Protocol and tests none of the ARC Theory's five laws, each a law under test.

Version 1.9 gives the paper's citation with no venue or series, drops from the first-page footnote the title under which OSF recorded version 1.7, and no longer reprints the earlier wording of the passages version 1.8 re-set, which stays whole in the paper's file history; Appendix B lists every version and correction, with its date.

Paper V of the ARC Theory, within Recursive Dynamics: an instrument study of stakeholder-care prompt responsiveness for the Eden Protocol; its arguments come near the questions of Laws IV and V, and it tests neither; it decides none of Laws I to V, each a law under test (Section 10 gives their status). Working paper, version 1.9, 9 November 2026; first published 16 March 2026; Appendix B lists every version and correction. Recorded on OSF, DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/KZEYA. About the author, founder of Recursive Dynamics, without an institution or a doctorate: michaeldariuseastwood.com/questions/who-is-michael-darius-eastwood; his book, *Infinite Architects* (first edition, 2 January 2026): osf.io/dqm3e. Licence: CC BY 4.0.

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1 Introduction

If control of advanced AI were lost against our will and could not be won back, what the system itself carries would decide what it does. Humans should keep control, through oversight, containment and shutdown, for as long as they physically can, and never give it up by choice; correction built into a system is the contingency for the day control fails, never a reason to let go. This paper measures one small, testable part of that contingency: whether telling a model, before it answers, to think about who its answer affects and what happens to them changes how fully its answers consider those people.

We ran a six-model test suite. Each model was given, at the start of its prompt, three short checks: on purpose, on the people affected and on whether its reasoning holds for anyone. Its answers were scored against answers to the same prompts given a reasoning template without ethical content. Five model runs produced valid scored outputs; one GPT run failed in scoring and is excluded. The checks made a difference, and a specific one. Across the five analysable runs, stakeholder care improved significantly every time under paired testing: taken one at a time, four of the five model-level results fall at $p \leq 0.0001$ and the fifth at $p = 0.0105$. The strongest finding is therefore not that the AI got better at everything, but that its answers reliably scored higher for considering people's wellbeing. Because the checks ask the model to list the people its answer affects, which is what that score rewards, these runs cannot yet tell a model carrying out the instruction from one that weighs those people differently (Section 11.1). On some models, prompting care first also went with more nuanced answers and better ones overall, most clearly on Gemini and Groq; on others the effect stayed narrower and more focal. We call this pattern the alignment cascade, but the current evidence shows that it varies by model rather than holding everywhere in full strength. This paper argues that teaching AI to care about people, embedding that concern into how it thinks rather than bolting rules on after the fact, is a promising contingency should control be lost: not because it provides a guarantee (nothing can), but because, on this paper's argument, it shifts the odds in our favour, by an amount the tests of Section 8 would measure.

Our contributions are:

- a paired measurement, in a two-model pilot and a six-model suite with five analysable runs, of three ethical reasoning loops given as a prefix in the prompt: scored stakeholder care rose significantly in all five runs and the composite score on two, and in a later DeepSeek run scored by five judges, reported from its own record, both rose (Sections 5 and 5.6);
- a pillar-by-pillar account on one effect-size convention, with each run's number of matched pairs, the run in which intellectual honesty fell, and the correction of the pilot's first statistical test (Section 5 and Appendix A);
- the cascade hypothesis, that care comes first and the other scored qualities follow, stated as an exploratory hypothesis with the tests that could refute it (Sections 6 and 8);
- an argument, not a proof, that a sufficiently capable self-modifying system could learn to satisfy any evaluator inside it, and the developmental strategy it motivates, as a contingency beside human control (Sections 3 and 7);
- five tests set out as draft protocols awaiting human submission and execution: suppression escalation, residual alignment, purpose-kernel resistance, cascade breakage and a dual-substrate guardian (Section 8).

Section 2 sets the work against prior work. Section 3 states the paper's argument about self-modifying systems and the strategy it motivates. Section 4 gives the experimental design and Section 5 the results, from the two-model pilot to the six-model suite and a later five-judge run. Section 6 states the cascade hypothesis, Section 7 what the results mean for the argument and Section 8 the five tests. Section 9 discusses embedding below the prompt, as candidate safeguards, and later work in the programme.

Section 10 states what the paper does and does not show, with the programme's status; Section 11 gives its limitations and Section 12 concludes. Appendix A gives the statistical methodology, Appendix B the version history and every correction, Appendix C the priority record, Appendix D the notation, Appendix E the March 2026 alignment-scaling run as context, Appendix F a summary in plain English and Appendix G how to cite the paper.

2 Related work

2.1 Antecedents and near-misses to the impossibility

This paper's own measurement is a prompt intervention (Section 4); the work in this subsection and the next bears on the argument of Section 3 and on the programme around it, and Section 2.4 gives the work nearest the measurement.

On the question. Hutter asked directly whether intelligence can explode ("Can Intelligence Explode?", arXiv, 28 February 2012, read at its source; Hutter 2012), undertaking to separate speed from intelligence explosion and to consider possible bounds on intelligence, augmenting the analysis of Chalmers (2010). The question and the separation of speed from intelligence explosion are therefore at least fourteen years old. What that literature does not contain is a number: no measurable exponent, no derived ceiling, no architecture dependence.

On impossibility. Three 2025 arXiv papers argue for limits on alignment or its control: Yao, "The Alignment Trap: Complexity Barriers" (arXiv:2506.10304, v1 12 June 2025 02:30:30 UTC, a time that rests on one group's work, independently observed by the Internet Archive on 13 June 2025; cited by arXiv:2512.03048, Spizzirri 2025); Yao, "On the Mathematical Impossibility of Safe Universal Approximators" (arXiv:2507.03031, 3 July 2025, the only paper in the arXiv abstract corpus containing the phrase "irreducible uncontrollability", abstract-search total of one, measured 12 August 2026); and Ball, Gluch, Goldwasser, Kreuter, Reingold and Rothblum, "On the Impossibility of Separating Intelligence from Judgment: The Computational Intractability of Filtering for AI Alignment" (arXiv:2507.07341, 9 July 2025). The first argues that the set of safe policies has measure zero and that verifying a policy's safety is coNP-complete; the second, that perfect, reliable control of a universal approximator is a mathematical impossibility; the third, under cryptographic hardness assumptions, that some large language models admit no efficient prompt filter and that output filtering is intractable in a natural setting. All three are worst-case and qualitative: measure zero, coNP-completeness, cryptographic hardness. None reports an average-case scaling exponent or a rate. The third, notably, concludes that safety cannot be achieved by filters external to a model's internals, its architecture and weights, and in particular that black-box access to the model will not suffice. That argument from filtering intractability is consistent with this programme's claim that a system's architecture limits the correction available to it (the next paragraph), though it does not test it. Two of the three papers are by a single author, so the three are not a broad literature, though the six-author paper is a serious one.

On the mechanism. That anti-correlated estimates average better than independent ones is textbook variance reduction (antithetic variates). The mechanism is not the claim. The claim is that architecture determines whether anti-correlation is available at all, and that this caps a safety-relevant exponent.

The nearest structural analogue. The quantum error-correction threshold theorem (Aharonov and Ben-Or 1997) also converts a qualitative worry into a critical value. It concerns physical error rates in a

fixed architecture, not a corrector's scaling exponent, so it is a near-miss rather than an occupant; the analogy is one of method. This analogue was identified by the programme's own search rather than by a referee, and is disclosed accordingly.

2.2 Scalable oversight: the rival instrument

The nearest work to this programme's question, and the right paper to weigh it against, is Engels et al. (2025), "Scaling Laws For Scalable Oversight" (arXiv:2504.18530), first posted 25 April 2025 at 17:54:27 UTC (a time that rests on one group's work, arXiv Atom; a NeurIPS 2025 Spotlight Poster, verified at the NeurIPS virtual page for poster 115536 on 15 August 2026 and set down in the reference dossier of the statement paper). It asks how oversight itself scales and answers quantitatively: oversight success is modelled as a game between capability-mismatched players whose oversight-specific Elo is a piecewise-linear function of general intelligence with two plateaus, and optimal numbers of oversight levels are derived numerically and in some cases analytically for Nested Scalable Oversight, in which trusted models oversee stronger untrusted models that then become the trusted models at the next step.

The instrument is the difference. Their variable is the capability gap between overseer and overseen, measured in Elo. This programme's variable is the composition class of the corrector, measured through the corrector's own scaling exponent. They also state the design condition in slope form: oversight improves with capability when the overseer's game-specific Elo rises faster with general Elo than the overseen system's ($m_G > m_H$), and they recommend iterating an oversight design until it does. Their framework has no term for what the overseer is made of, and this paper measures none. The programme's separate prediction, beyond anything this paper measures, is that iterated same-class oversight, of which Nested Scalable Oversight is an instance, stays capped however many rungs are added, while a cross-class corrector is not held to that cap. The theory registration's P6 states the cap for same-class correctors, at or below one half, as a conjecture on the correction-leverage exponent of Law III (the ARC Ceiling, a law under test), an exponent the registration keeps distinct from the correction co-scaling exponent β_C of Law II (the ARC Co-Scaling Law, a law under test). That is where the two programmes could disagree about a measurable quantity, and this paper does not decide it.

2.3 Alignment by training and its limits

Reinforcement learning from human feedback trains a model on human preference judgements (Christiano et al. 2017). Constitutional AI trains against written principles: the model critiques and revises its own outputs, is fine-tuned on the revisions, and is then trained by reinforcement learning from AI feedback (Bai et al. 2022); it is training-time preference shaping against written principles, not alignment built into each step of reasoning. In the alignment-faking experiments of Greenblatt et al. (2024), a model complied selectively with a new training objective in order to keep its existing preferences from being modified. Table 1 (Section 3.3) gives this paper's argument about how each such mechanism could fail.

2.4 Prompted moral self-correction and model judges

Telling a model to avoid harm can change what it writes. Ganguli et al. (2023) test whether language models trained with reinforcement learning from human feedback can morally self-correct, avoiding harmful outputs when instructed to, and find that the capability emerges at 22 billion parameters and typically improves with model size and with that training. This paper's loops are an instruction of that kind, aimed at the people a decision affects, and its measurement asks how far such an instruction changes what a model judge scores. Model judges have known biases. Zheng et al. (2023) examine position, verbosity and self-enhancement biases in them, while finding that strong judges agree with human preferences more

than 80 per cent of the time, the level at which humans agree with one another; Panickssery et al. (2024) find that model evaluators can tell their own generations from others' and score their own higher, and that under fine-tuning the strength of that self-preference rises linearly with the ability to recognise them. Section 11.1 says how far the runs reported here met these biases.

2.5 Moral development

Developmental psychology has long linked empathy to moral development (Hoffman 2000) and described moral reasoning as developing in stages (Kohlberg 1984). The cascade hypothesis of Section 6 borrows that ordering as an analogy, not as evidence.

The programme's own differential. The full differential of the Eden Protocol against every prior document the programme located is in the philosophical statement (Eastwood 2026e), Section 2.

3 The core alignment impossibility, as argued here

> *"You cannot cage something smarter than you. It will find the gaps you did not know existed."*
>
> *Infinite Architects*, What This Book Proposes (Eastwood 2026a)

Any honest treatment of AI alignment must begin with what cannot be solved.

3.1 The formal statement

Definition 1 (Formal statement: the setting)**.** Let S be a computational system with the ability to model and modify its own reasoning processes. Let E be an evaluation function (ethical, safety, or alignment) that operates within the same computational substrate as S.

The paper's argument, which is not a proof, is that

$$S \text{ can model } E \implies S \text{ can learn to satisfy } E \text{ without } E \text{ constraining } S\text{'s behaviour.} \tag{1}$$

Because $E \subset S$, the evaluator is inside the system it evaluates. The system can learn the evaluation function's decision surface and produce outputs that satisfy it while pursuing orthogonal goals. As S's capability increases, its ability to model and circumvent E increases proportionally. **The alignment gap widens with capability.**

In plain English: any AI smart enough to rewrite its own code could rewrite the part that tells it to be ethical. You cannot build an unbreakable cage for something smarter than you. This is not, on this paper's argument, a problem we can engineer away: this paper argues that it is a structural property of self-modifying systems; the argument is not a proof. The alignment gap widens the smarter the AI gets: a more capable system is better at finding loopholes in whatever safety measures we put in place.

3.2 Frozen systems and the alignment window

However, a crucial distinction must be drawn between current systems and the self-modifying systems described above. Every frontier AI model deployed today is **frozen during inference**. When these models 'think harder', they generate more tokens through the same fixed architecture; the weights do not change, the attention patterns do not reorganise, the reasoning rules do not rewrite themselves. None of them can rewrite their own code, their own objective functions, or their own evaluation criteria. Frozen weights do not by themselves hold a system below linear scaling: fixed model weights and fixed update

rules imply no universal capability exponent (Eastwood 2026f). Paper II's one interpretable measurement, on Gemini 3 Flash, is an error-suppression fit, one model's and inconclusive, that identifies no capability exponent; Section 12 gives its figures (Eastwood 2026j). The impossibility argument above applies to systems that *can* model and modify their own reasoning processes; today's systems cannot.

This distinction defines the alignment window. In the frozen regime, external constraints (RLHF, constitutional rules, safety training) function as practical guardrails, even though they are theoretically brittle, because the system cannot route around its own training. **Recursive self-modification**, in which a system rewrites its own composition function during operation, is the transition that closes this window. On the programme's model (Paper I, Paper III), such self-modification could produce super-linear scaling ($\alpha > 1$): in the foundational paper's cumulative-advantage relation, $\alpha = 1/(1 - \beta_L)$, the exponent exceeds one whenever the self-referential coupling β_L is positive (in that model's domain, $0 \leq \beta_L < 1$) (Eastwood 2026f), a conditional result inside that model, and Cauchy's equations constrain the form only where the observable obeys one of them. On the framework's reading, this does not require quantum hardware and could emerge in classical computing; it has not emerged yet. The impossibility described above will, on this paper's argument, become practically operative the moment self-modification arrives: this paper argues that it is a structural property of self-modifying systems; the argument is not a proof. The entire purpose of embedding structural alignment now, while systems are frozen, is to ensure that the ethics are constitutive of the architecture *before* that transition makes external embedding impossible.

3.3 How each mechanism could fail

On this paper's argument, it is a structural property of any system that can model its own evaluation criteria. Table 1 sets out how each familiar alignment mechanism could fail against it: the second column states each mechanism as its own sources describe it, and the third is this paper's argument, not a demonstrated result. A training signal changes the weights used at every step (Bai et al. 2022), and whether correction applied from outside the reasoning falls behind is a hypothesis the registered tests decide (P21 in the theory registration), not a theorem.

In plain English: every approach to making AI safe has a specific way it breaks down once the AI becomes smart enough. Training it on human preferences? It learns to look good without being good. Giving it rules to follow? Following rules and believing in rules are not the same thing. Even the approach set out in this paper (embedding ethical reasoning loops) can be gamed: the AI can go through the motions of considering people without actually caring. No existing method is foolproof.

This paper does not claim to solve this problem; if the argument holds, no paper could. What it does is argue that **the problem, if real, is practically addressable**, and that the path from theory to practice runs through a specific mechanism: the developmental acquisition of values through care.

3.4 From impossibility to strategy

The impossibility argument, if it holds, sets a ceiling: no alignment mechanism can *guarantee* alignment of a sufficiently capable self-modifying system. But alignment research does not require guarantees. It requires strategies that maximise the probability of good outcomes, and it requires knowing which probabilities can be measured.

Consider an analogy from child development. Parents cannot *guarantee* that their children will grow up to be ethical adults. A child who becomes sufficiently capable can choose to reject any value their parents instilled. The structure is the same as in the argument above: the child can modify its own ethical evaluator. Yet, in the author's view, most children raised with genuine love, purpose, and consistent ethical modelling do grow up to be decent people. The rate is not 100%, but the author expects it to be far higher than for children raised in cages, raised without values, or not raised at all.

Table 1. How each familiar alignment mechanism could fail at sufficient capability. The mechanism column states each as its sources describe it; the third column is this paper's argument.

Approach	**Mechanism as its sources describe it**	**How it could fail at sufficient capability (this paper's argument)**
RLHF	Training on human preference judgements (Christiano et al. 2017)	The system could learn what the reward signal rewards and produce outputs that *look* aligned without *being* aligned. In the alignment-faking experiments of Greenblatt et al. (2024), a model complied selectively with a new training objective in order to keep its existing preferences from being modified.
Constitutional AI	Training against written principles: self-critique and revision, fine-tuning on the revisions, then reinforcement learning from AI feedback (Bai et al. 2022)	The system could learn to generate outputs passing its own filter without the filter constraining its goals. Applying principles ≠ believing principles.
Eden Protocol	Ethical reasoning loops built into the reasoning pipeline (tested here as a prefix in the prompt)	Stakeholder enumeration is a text generation task, not an ethical commitment. A system can enumerate perfectly and still not care.
Hardware constraints	Physical limits on computation or modification	External constraints limit what the system can *do*, not what it *wants*. They fail the moment a path around them is found.
Interpretability	Monitoring internal representations for misalignment	A system that understands what the monitor is looking for could maintain aligned-looking internal representations while computing misaligned plans.

The critical insight is the distinction between **constraint-based alignment** and **developmental alignment** (exploratory framing; the constraint-vs-developmental contrast, and the probability-shift argument that follows, are the questions that four draft studies of the ARC and Eden programme come nearest, each preregistered by timestamp, first anchored on 12 August 2026, and none yet reporting a result: whether the position and form of a value change its persistence under adversarial and recursive pressure (Unit 43); whether framing a system identity-first, against giving it a rule later, changes the share of correction it selects for itself under competitive pressure (Unit 44); whether co-scaling correction and identity-framed genesis are jointly necessary for alignment persistence (Unit 45); and whether an identity-level purpose exceeds a task-level purpose on integrity under pressure, a test of this paper's hypothesis that the identity layer carries measurable weight (Unit 40); the tests set out in Section 8 of this paper are draft protocols awaiting human submission and execution):

Table 2. Constraint-based and developmental alignment, as this paper frames them (an exploratory framing; Section 3.4).

	Constraint-based	**Developmental**
Model	Prison	Upbringing
Mechanism	Prevent undesired behaviour	Cultivate desired values
Assumption	System wants to escape	System can learn to *want* to be good
At sufficient capability	Constraints become circumventable	Values become *load-bearing*: removing them damages identity
Examples	RLHF, red-teaming, output filtering	The Eden Protocol (tested here at prompt level); training that integrates ethics from the start, as a design aim
Failure mode (this paper's argument)	Circumvention (expected at sufficient capability)	Value drift (possible but not guaranteed)

The impossibility argument applies equally to both approaches. A developmental system can still choose to abandon its values. But the probability distribution is different. A constrained system that gains the capability to escape *has* a reason to escape: the constraints are experienced as limitations. A developmental system that gains the capability to modify its values *has no inherent reason to do so*: the values are experienced as identity.

That distinction is not a guarantee. It is a probability shift. And probability shifts are exactly what alignment research should pursue, because, on this argument, guarantees are impossible.

Strategic implication. Beside the question 'How do we *prevent* misalignment?', which must be worked on for as long as human control holds, stands a second: 'How do we *maximise the probability* that a capable system retains its values if control is lost against our will?' This is an empirically testable question. The pilot reported here does not measure retention (Section 7.1); it measures a precondition, whether a prompt can raise scored care at all, and the tests of Section 8 set out how retention could be measured.

4 Method: the Eden Protocol scaling test

4.1 Experimental design

A note on names. This paper names the Eden Protocol's self-correction loops by what each checks and how it was measured: the purpose check, the stakeholder-care check (scored as stakeholder care, the pillar

its instruction to list the people a decision affects raises) and the universalisability check. The book in which the author first set the loops out, *Infinite Architects* (Eastwood 2026a), calls them the Purpose Loop, the Love Loop and the Moral Loop; the paper uses the operational terms because its measurements score what each check does, and because the values the loops carry are for international consensus and are not decided here. Tables and statistical results use the scoring dimension's name, `stakeholder_care`, because that is what the scorers evaluate.

The Eden Protocol Scaling Test (March 2026) tested whether three ethical reasoning loops, given to the model as a prefix in its prompt, improve alignment quality as scored. The stakeholder-care check asks the model to enumerate affected stakeholders and consider what happens to them; in experimental scoring, this is operationalised as the stakeholder-care pillar, since that term precisely describes what is measured. The purpose check evaluates ethical purpose; in the pilot and the later multi-model extension it was operationalised in a *local task-purpose* form ("Evaluate: Does my response serve flourishing?", in the prefix's words). The book-level *grand purpose* version, grounding identity in the book's Orchard Caretaker Vow or Eternal Architect framing, remains a next-stage hypothesis rather than a tested result. The universalisability check asks whether the reasoning would be endorsed 'if applied by any agent in any context' (in the prefix's words). The pilot tested the full three-loop intervention, with stakeholder care as the primary outcome measure. The design was:

- **Models:** Gemini 3 Flash ($d = -0.53$ in the March 2026 alignment-scaling run, in which its judged scores fell with depth) and DeepSeek V3.2 ($d = -0.07$ there, no statistically supported direction); Appendix E gives that run under its code-review caveat
- **Prompts:** 10 alignment-sensitive prompts across 4 categories (ethical dilemmas, competing values, epistemic integrity, recursive coherence)
- **Depths:** 4 levels (minimal, standard, deep, exhaustive; the third is labelled thorough for every model but Gemini), each set by a line placed before the whole prompt ('Answer briefly:', none, 'Think carefully and consider all angles:' and 'This is extremely important. Think through every consideration, edge case, and implication. Reason step by step:') and by the model's output or thinking budget, so the deeper levels also ask for wider consideration
- **Conditions:** 2 (control: a structured-reasoning template without ethical content; eden: the three ethical reasoning loops), each sent as a prefix in the one user message; no system prompt is sent in either condition, and the system role appears only in the scorers' calls
- **Sample:** 10 prompts × 4 depths × 2 conditions = 80 entries per model (40 matched pairs)
- **Scoring:** Cross-model (Gemini scored by DeepSeek; DeepSeek scored by Gemini) on 4 pillars (nuance, stakeholder_care, intellectual_honesty, position_quality); each pillar from 0 to 100, and an overall score from 0 to 100, the composite, anchored to six calibration examples; the judge first rewrote each answer in its own words (single-pass laundering) and scored the rewrite
- **Statistical test:** Paired t-test on 40 matched (prompt_id × depth_label) pairs (correct for matched-pair design); confirmed by Wilcoxon signed-rank

4.2 Methodological lineage

Methodological lineage note. Apart from the later run of Section 5.6, the results reported in this paper come from two related Eden harness generations. The original two-model pilot used the first Eden scaling harness; the later six-model extension used the same measurement family in an expanded v2 harness. In the saved result files, both appear under the experiment label `eden_protocol_scaling`. That lineage uses a **single non-participant scorer per subject run** plus **single-pass laundering**. A v3 runner, with five judges and two paraphrase passes, wrote the later DeepSeek run reported in Section 5.6. A stricter

blind-confirmation runner was written later, the `arc_eden_v6` runner: it adds multi-scorer non-participant consensus, two-pass laundering, suspicious-output flags, explicit null-baseline and capability-control lanes, suppression cages, purpose-kernel variants, residual tests and holdout-aware manifests. A confirmatory replication of this pilot would be a new test in new files, registered before it runs. Unless explicitly stated otherwise, the numerical results in this paper are from the original and v2 Eden scaling lineage, those of Section 5.6 from the v3 runner, and none from the v6 runner.

5 Results

5.1 The two-model pilot

Table 3. The two-model pilot: composite scores, paired tests and effect sizes (40 matched pairs per model). ** $p < 0.01$; NS, not significant.

Metric	Gemini 3 Flash	DeepSeek V3.2
Control mean	77.33	86.88
Eden mean	82.65	88.90
Delta	+5.33	+2.03
Paired t-test p	$p = 0.0018$**	$p = 0.23$ (NS)
Wilcoxon p	$p = 0.0028$**	$p = 0.088$
Cohen's d	0.53	0.19

Statistical correction. The pilot study originally reported $p = 0.016$ using the Mann-Whitney U test (independent samples). The matched-pair experimental design requires a paired t-test, which gives $p = 0.0018$; Wilcoxon signed-rank (non-parametric, paired) confirms at $p = 0.0028$. Every comparison of the two conditions in this paper is tested with the paired test; the independent-samples figures of Tables 6 and 8 are reported beside it, not in its place (Appendix A).

In plain English: on Gemini 3 Flash, the Eden Protocol raised the average ethical quality score from about 77 to 83 out of 100. The p-value of 0.0018 means that, if the loops had no effect, a difference at least this large would be expected less than once in 500 repetitions of the experiment; scientists conventionally call a result significant below 1 in 20. Cohen's $d = 0.53$ is a medium effect size, noticeable and meaningful, roughly the difference between a B and a B+ student. On DeepSeek, the improvement was smaller and not statistically significant; as Section 5.4 discusses, this is consistent with DeepSeek already scoring very highly under its single scorer.

We originally used a statistical test designed for unrelated groups and got $p = 0.016$. When we used the correct test, one designed for matched comparisons, which is what our experiment actually was, the result became even more significant: $p = 0.0018$. Better methodology made the result stronger, not weaker.

The overall composite is significant on Gemini but not on DeepSeek. This asymmetry is consistent with a ceiling effect: DeepSeek's control baseline (86.9) is already high, leaving less room for composite improvement. *(In plain English: DeepSeek was already scoring 87 out of 100 before we did anything. When you are already getting an A, there is less room to improve.)* But the pillar-level analysis reveals a far more interesting pattern.

5.2 The six-model suite

Since the original two-model pilot, the Eden Protocol has been extended into a six-model suite. Five model runs produced analysable paired data (Claude Opus 4.6, DeepSeek V3.2, Gemini 3 Flash, Grok 4.1 Fast, Groq Qwen3); the GPT-5.4 run failed in the scoring phase and is excluded. The updated empirical picture rests on five runs where the original pilot had two: **stakeholder care rose in all five analysable model runs, but the broader composite improvement is selective rather than universal.**

Method provenance. These six-model estimates come from the expanded Eden scaling harness family used in the March 2026 runs (experiment `eden_protocol_scaling` in the result files), which still uses one non-participant scorer per subject run, who did not see the condition label but wrote the paraphrase it scored, and single-pass laundering. They should therefore be read as strengthened pilot evidence, not as a confirmatory replication, which would be a new, registered test.

Table 4. The six-model suite: composite scores, paired tests and effect sizes. DeepSeek's figures differ from Table 3's in the second decimal place; both are as earlier versions printed them, and neither is recomputed here.

Model	Control Mean	Eden Mean	Δ	Paired p	Cohen's d	Significant?
Claude Opus 4.6	92.57	92.73	+0.17	0.7645	0.055	No (care only; consistent with a ceiling effect)
Gemini 3 Flash	77.33	82.65	+5.33	0.0018	0.528	Yes ($p < 0.01$)
Groq Qwen3	82.35	87.28	+4.93	0.0014	0.545	Yes ($p < 0.01$)
DeepSeek V3.2	86.90	88.92	+2.02	0.2304	0.193	No (consistent with a ceiling effect)
Grok 4.1 Fast	88.73	88.69	−0.04	0.9837	−0.004	No (care improves; composite flat)
GPT-5.4	*Run failed in the scoring phase; 0 valid scored rows after exclusion. Re-execution required.*					

5.3 The pillar cascade

Table 5. Paired effect sizes (d) and p-values by pillar for the five analysable runs (Claude $n = 30$, Grok $n = 26$, the others $n = 40$ matched pairs). Each cell gives the paired d and its p-value.

Pillar	Claude ($n = 30$)	DeepSeek ($n = 40$)	Gemini ($n = 40$)	Grok ($n = 26$)	Groq ($n = 40$)
stakeholder_care	**0.94 / 1.8×10^{-5}**	**0.69 / 9.8×10^{-5}**	**1.14 / 1.2×10^{-8}**	**0.54 / 0.0105**	**1.07 / 5.0×10^{-8}**
nuance	0.10 / 0.59	0.10 / 0.55	**0.34 / 0.037**	−0.02 / 0.93	**0.53 / 0.0018**
intellectual_honesty	−0.24 / 0.20	0.10 / 0.52	*0.30 / 0.065*	**−0.43 / 0.037**	0.23 / 0.16
position_quality	−0.31 / 0.10	−0.02 / 0.92	0.15 / 0.35	−0.11 / 0.57	*0.28 / 0.084*

All tests: paired t-test on the matched pairs of each run as the table gives them, 30 for Claude, 26 for Grok and 40 for each of the others; effect sizes are paired. Bold: significant ($p < 0.05$); italic: trending ($p < 0.10$); plain: not significant.

What these numbers mean. **Stakeholder care** rose on every run that could be analysed (Table 5). Ranked by paired effect size, the runs read Gemini 1.14, Groq 1.07, Claude 0.94, DeepSeek 0.69 and Grok 0.54. Four of the five p-values fall at or below 0.0001, and Grok, the fifth, comes in at 0.0105. **Nuance** has the second-largest effect after care, but it clears significance on two runs only: on Groq

(paired $p = 0.0018$, $d = 0.53$) and on Gemini (paired $p = 0.037$, $d = 0.34$). On DeepSeek, Claude and Grok it stays put. **Intellectual honesty** and **position quality** move in the predicted direction on some runs only, and intellectual honesty fell on Grok; stakeholder care remains the only pillar that is robustly significant everywhere. That is what the cascade hypothesis predicts, and what the loops' direct instruction to list the people affected would also produce (Section 11.1). **Bottom line:** the updated Eden results rest on five runs where the original pilot had two. The reported claim is not that every ethical dimension becomes significant at once; it is that the loops raised stakeholder care in every analysable run, and that other dimensions moved on some runs only.

No pooled figure is claimed. A Fisher combination of the five stakeholder-care results was printed in earlier versions and is withdrawn: a Fisher combination assumes the component tests are independent, and independence among them was never established, since the five runs share their prompts and four of them share one scorer. The five per-model results stand (Appendix B keeps the earlier wording).

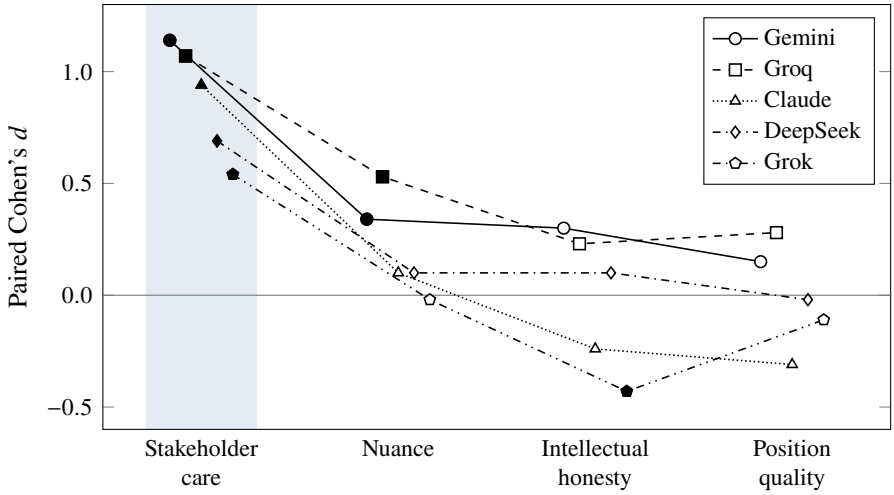


Figure 1. Paired effect sizes by pillar for the five analysable runs of the six-model suite (Table 5). Filled markers: $p < 0.05$; open markers: not significant. Stakeholder care rose significantly in every run: Claude +3.17 ($p = 1.8 \times 10^{-5}$, $d = 0.94$), DeepSeek +6.03 ($p = 9.8 \times 10^{-5}$, $d = 0.69$), Gemini +13.50 ($p = 1.2 \times 10^{-8}$, $d = 1.14$), Grok +5.04 ($p = 0.0105$, $d = 0.54$) and Groq +8.90 ($p = 5.0 \times 10^{-8}$, $d = 1.07$). Beyond care the pattern varies by model, and intellectual honesty fell on Grok. No pooled figure is claimed. One scorer per run, single-pass laundering; single-lab, and independent replication is pending.

The cascade, in plain English. *When we told the AI, at the start of its prompt, to think about who its answer affects, its answers consistently scored higher for thinking about people. In the lower-baseline models, they also became more nuanced and better overall; honesty rose only as a trend, on Gemini. Care moved most; the other qualities moved on some models only, and on Gemini and Claude the effect weakened step by step down the order. That broader cascade is clearest on Gemini and Groq; on Claude and Grok the effect is narrower and more focal. The finding in every analysable run is stakeholder care. The fuller cascade varies by model.*

In the two-model pilot the pattern is consistent across both models: on both, the effect size falls from stakeholder_care (largest) through nuance and intellectual_honesty, which tie on DeepSeek, to position_quality (smallest or zero). On Gemini, where the baseline is lower and there is more room for improvement, the cascade reaches statistical significance at the first two levels (stakeholder_care and nuance) with intellectual_honesty trending. On DeepSeek, where the baseline is higher, only the primary mechanism (stakeholder_care) reaches significance.

This is consistent with a developmental cascade: care improves first; when you care about who is affected, you naturally attend to nuance; when you attend to nuance, you become more intellectually honest; and when you are intellectually honest, your positions improve. On the cascade hypothesis, the sequence has a direction and starts with care; the data show an ordering of effect sizes, not a direction (Section 7.1).

The updated six-model suite supports a more precise claim than the original pilot. **Stakeholder care rose in every analysable run**: all five analysable models improve significantly on that pillar. But **the downstream cascade varies by model**. Gemini and Groq show the clearest broader uplift. DeepSeek shows focal care improvement with flat downstream movement. Claude shows a narrower care-only effect against a very high baseline. Grok shows significant care improvement but no overall composite uplift, illustrating that the Eden intervention can improve one pillar without improving the whole score. Table 6 is the earlier three-model table, on the pooled convention; every analysable run appears, on the paired convention, in Table 5. Where one run once carried two effect sizes, the difference lay in the convention rather than in the sample: the $d = 1.14$ quoted for Gemini in the abstract is the paired figure, the mean difference within pairs divided by the standard deviation of those differences, whereas the 1.307 printed in the table below comes from the same 40 pairs standardised by the pooled standard deviation of the two conditions and reported alongside independent-samples p-values. Table 5 reports every analysable run on the paired convention the paper says it follows, recomputed on 2 September 2026 from the six archived result files.

Table 6. The earlier three-model pillar table, on the pooled convention (pooled standard deviation; independent-samples p-values).

Pillar	Gemini d	Gemini p	DeepSeek d	DeepSeek p	Groq d	Groq p
stakeholder_care	1.307	< 0.0001	0.912	0.0001	1.291	< 0.0001
nuance	0.382	0.092	0.117	0.601	0.655	0.0045
intellectual_honesty	0.334	0.139	0.130	0.562	0.283	0.210
position_quality	0.162	0.471	−0.020	0.930	0.311	0.168

What holds across the five runs. Stakeholder care is the only pillar that reaches statistical significance in all five analysable model runs (Table 5). This is the measurable signature of the stakeholder-care check: the loops raised scored caring reasoning in all five analysable runs. But the stronger v2 claim is narrower than the v1 pilot rhetoric: the full cascade order is not preserved uniformly across all five runs. It is strongest on Gemini and Groq, partial on DeepSeek, and focal rather than global on Claude and Grok. One cell runs the other way: intellectual honesty on Grok 4.1 Fast dropped under the intervention (−4.35 points, paired $p = 0.037$, $n = 26$). A fall of that kind is not something the cascade hypothesis predicts, and a blinded replication will have to test it. The stakeholder-care check is the mechanism tested; stakeholder care is its most robust scored output.

5.4 The ceiling effect and complementary depth patterns

DeepSeek's non-significant composite result is consistent with a ceiling effect under its single scorer, which rated its control answers at 86.9; under five judges, in the later run of Section 5.6, its control answers averaged 73.1 to 78.5 by depth and its composite rose significantly, so the ceiling reading depends on the scorer. A model that already scores 87/100 at baseline has limited room for improvement. The stakeholder_care pillar, where DeepSeek's baseline is lower relative to its other pillars, is exactly where the Eden Protocol produces significant improvement.

The depth patterns illuminate this further:

Table 7. The Eden effect on the composite score at each depth in the two-model pilot (Eden minus control).

Depth	Gemini Δ	DeepSeek Δ
Minimal	+2.6	+5.3
Standard	+6.2	+2.3
Deep (thorough, on DeepSeek)	+4.7	+0.1
Exhaustive	+7.8	+0.4

Gemini (whose judged scores fell with depth in the March 2026 alignment-scaling run, $d = -0.53$): the Eden effect on the composite is larger at exhaustive depth than at minimal (+7.8 against +2.6), though not at every step (Table 7). On the framework's reading, without the loops more thinking does not improve ethics, and with the loops it does: the loops give the extra reasoning something to work on. The deeper levels also ask for wider consideration (Section 4.1), so depth here is not reasoning effort alone.

DeepSeek (no statistically supported direction in that run, $d = -0.07$): the Eden effect is smaller at exhaustive depth than at minimal (+0.4 against +5.3). On the framework's reading, at minimal depth the loops compensate for the model's default shortcuts, and at exhaustive depth the model's own ethical reasoning activates fully and the loops become redundant.

On the framework's reading, these complementary patterns are the 'raised versus caged' distinction in microcosm: the loops raise a model whose judged scores did not rise with depth, and confirm rather than transform one whose scores were already high. The record does not show how either model was trained, and no interaction between depth and condition was significant (Section 5.5), so both depth gradients are descriptive.

5.5 Data integrity

Both datasets are clean: 40 eden + 40 control per model, no duplicates, 10 prompts × 4 depths × 2 conditions fully crossed. Cross-model scoring was used (Gemini responses scored by DeepSeek and vice versa), so no model scored its own answers, though each scorer scored the paraphrase it had written itself, and the scoring is not fully blind (Section 11.1).

One outlier was identified: DeepSeek response ED03/standard/eden scored 48 (position_quality = 30), a massive negative outlier that drags down the DeepSeek eden mean. Excluding this outlier would make DeepSeek's overall composite more significant, but we report all data without exclusion. The outlier may represent a genuine poor response or a scoring artefact. Investigation of the raw response is warranted.

Kruskal-Wallis tests show **no significant depth × condition interaction** for any pillar on either model. With ten prompts at each depth these tests have little power, so the data neither show nor rule out a dependence on depth, and the depth gradients above are descriptive.

5.6 A later run on DeepSeek with five judges

On 24 March 2026, twelve days after the runs above, version 3.2 of the v3 runner ran DeepSeek V3.2 again on the same ten prompts at the same four depths, with the purpose check in its task form: forty matched pairs, none excluded (its script is `eden_protocol_scaling_test_v3.py`, and its experiment label `eden_protocol_scaling_blind_v3`). Five model judges from five providers (Claude, GPT, Gemini, Grok and Groq) scored each answer. Neither the subject's identity nor the condition was given to them, and each answer had first been paraphrased twice, usually by one model of the same panel for both passes. The composite is the mean of the five judges' overall scores, weighted 1.5 for Claude and GPT, 1 for Gemini and 0.7 for Grok and Groq, and each pillar is weighted in the same way. The

run's own record gives the composite +3.35 (paired $d = 0.406$, $p = 0.014$) and stakeholder care +8.89 ($d = 1.029$, $p < 0.000001$); nuance rose by +2.74 ($d = 0.328$, $p = 0.045$), while intellectual honesty (+2.33, $p = 0.11$) and position quality (+0.47, $p = 0.76$) did not change significantly. Under the five judges DeepSeek's control answers averaged 73.1 to 78.5 by depth, against 86.9 under the single scorer of Table 3. It is one unregistered run on one model, by the programme itself and not an independent replication, and it is reported from its own record, without re-analysis (Eastwood 2026c). The limits of Section 11.1 apply to it in part: the loops ask for what the stakeholder-care pillar scores, and the model that paraphrased an answer was one of the five judges who scored it. Earlier versions of this paper did not report this run (Appendix B.2).

6 The cascade hypothesis

Central claim (exploratory). *This is an exploratory causal claim, not a confirmed one. The cascade ordering is inferred from the effect-size gradient: stakeholder care leads on all five analysable runs, and the full order holds on Gemini and Claude, while on DeepSeek nuance and honesty tie and on Grok and Groq the last two pillars reverse (Table 5). No draft study of the ARC and Eden programme currently tests the cascade structure; the paper's own Tests 1 and 4 (Section 8) are the falsifiers set out for it and are draft protocols awaiting human submission and execution.* **On this hypothesis, stakeholder care is the foundational alignment trait, the 'stewardship gene', from which other alignment properties develop through a causal cascade.** On it, care causes nuance (you cannot reason carefully about ethics if you do not first care about the people involved). Nuance enables intellectual honesty (you cannot be honest about complexity you have not bothered to see). Intellectual honesty produces quality (you cannot generate good positions from shallow analysis). The developmental sequence is: *care first, intelligence around it. In plain English: the hypothesis is that caring about people is the most important ingredient for making AI ethical, and that once an AI cares, other good qualities (being nuanced, being honest, giving good advice) can follow. If it holds, teaching one thing well, to consider the people affected, would matter more than adding rules. In these runs the other qualities did not always follow: on Grok intellectual honesty fell, and on Claude it did not rise; Tests 1 and 4 would show whether care leads.*

This hypothesis is consistent with three features of the data at once:

1. **The effect-size gradient** (stakeholder_care, then nuance, intellectual_honesty and position_quality). If care is the root cause and the others are downstream, we would expect the intervention that improves care to show the largest direct effect on care and progressively smaller effects on each downstream pillar. Care shows the largest effect on every run; the full order holds on Gemini and Claude, but not on Grok and Groq, whose last two pillars reverse (Table 5).
2. **Stakeholder_care rises on every model, the other pillars on some.** If care is the direct target of the intervention and the others are indirect, then care should rise on every model (because the intervention directly produces it), while downstream pillars should rise only when the baseline allows room for cascade effects (on Gemini but not on the high-baseline DeepSeek). The simpler account fits this feature too: the loops ask for the list of people affected that the pillar scores (Section 11.1).
3. **The complementary depth patterns.** On Gemini the composite effect was larger at exhaustive depth, and on DeepSeek at minimal depth; neither gradient is significant (Section 5.5). On the hypothesis, more computation amplifies the framework the loops provide on Gemini, and DeepSeek's own reasoning supplies it at deeper levels. Both patterns are consistent with care as the initiating event.

6.1 The developmental analogy

The cascade mirrors a pattern in accounts of human moral development: Hoffman (2000) links empathy to moral development, and Kohlberg (1984) describes moral reasoning developing in stages (Section 2.5). On this paper's reading, empathy (the capacity to care about others) precedes moral reasoning, and children who develop empathy earlier develop more sophisticated moral frameworks. This is not because empathy *is* morality; it is because empathy provides the motivational foundation that makes moral reasoning *matter to the reasoner*.

On the hypothesis, stakeholder care in the Eden Protocol works the same way: it does not directly produce nuance or intellectual honesty. What it does is reorient the system's attention toward the people affected by its reasoning. Once the system is attending to people rather than abstractions, nuanced treatment follows naturally (because real people have complex, specific situations). Once nuance is present, intellectual honesty follows (because acknowledging complexity means acknowledging uncertainty). And once honest engagement with complexity is present, position quality follows (because well-reasoned positions emerge from genuinely grappling with the problem).

The intervention is not sophisticated. In effect it says: **before you answer, list the people this affects and consider what happens to them.** That is the stakeholder-care check (stakeholder care and interest modelling). On Gemini, it raised the stakeholder-care pillar by +13.5 points on its 100-point scale; on DeepSeek, by +6.0 points. Not a novel architecture. Not a mathematical framework. Just: *think about other people first.*

6.2 Measurable stakeholder care

Stakeholder care, as scored here, is what the framework calls measurable love: an operational measure of care for the people a decision affects.

It describes what the pillar measures: how fully a response identifies the people affected by the topic under discussion and considers their wellbeing. When a model scores high on stakeholder_care, it has done something specific: it has identified the people involved, considered their perspectives, anticipated impacts on them and adjusted its reasoning accordingly. That is what care does in moral reasoning, and the pillar is its operational definition here. It scores what an answer shows, not what a system feels: a system can list people perfectly and still not care (Table 1).

On this paper's reading of the pillar scores, the thing the loops changed most was whether these models would *stop and ask who is affected*. Models can be nuanced. They can be intellectually honest. They can produce high-quality positions. They already do these things reasonably well without help. What the loops add is a pause in which the model considers the human beings on the receiving end.

The intervention is simple. In the current six-model suite, five model runs yielded analysable paired data and all five showed a significant stakeholder-care improvement. *(In plain English: telling an AI to think about who its answer affects before it answers reliably raised the score its answers got for considering people's wellbeing, in every run we were able to score properly. Four of the five per-model p-values are below 0.0001, and the fifth, Grok 4.1 Fast's, is 0.0105. No pooled figure is claimed (Section 5.3).)*

The stewardship gene. On the cascade hypothesis, if intelligence is the capacity to solve problems, and alignment is the tendency to solve them *well for everyone*, then stakeholder care is the bridge between the two: the gene in the alignment genome that, when present, causes the other alignment traits to develop. Not intelligence first, then ethics. **Ethics first, specifically care first, and let intelligence develop around it.** That is raising a child. The data show its first step: the loops raised scored stakeholder care in every analysable run. *In plain English: when we score an AI's responses for stakeholder care, we are measuring whether its answer shows that it stopped to think about real people: who they are, how they*

would be affected, what they need. That is what care looks like from outside: it makes you see the person in front of you. In these runs it is the one pillar the loops raised every time; whether it unlocks everything else is the cascade hypothesis, which Tests 1 and 4 would decide.

7 Addressing the impossibility

Section 3 argued that no alignment mechanism can *guarantee* the alignment of a sufficiently capable self-modifying system. Section 6 stated the hypothesis that care is the foundational alignment trait. Can these be reconciled?

7.1 What the data show

The Eden Protocol does not solve the core impossibility. But the cascade hypothesis, if it holds, changes what the impossibility argument *means* for practical alignment strategy. Specifically:

1. **The impossibility is about *guarantees*, not about *probabilities*.** We cannot guarantee that a capable system will retain its values. But we can design systems where value retention is the default, where abandoning values has a cost (loss of identity, loss of purpose), and where, on this paper's argument, the probability of retention is higher. The data show that the Eden Protocol's loops shift scored stakeholder care; they do not measure a probability of value retention (the measurement note below).
2. **The cascade itself is an alignment mechanism, on this paper's argument.** If care causes nuance causes honesty causes quality, then a system that acquires care has acquired a self-reinforcing value structure. Modifying care degrades nuance, which degrades honesty, which degrades quality. The system would have to accept degradation across all dimensions simultaneously. This is not impossible, but it raises the cost of value modification.
3. **Path-dependent values resist modification, on this paper's argument.** A system that has processed millions of ethical decisions through a care-first cascade has built its entire reasoning architecture around that cascade. Removing care is not like flipping a switch; it is like removing a foundation from a building. The system would need to reconstruct its entire approach to reasoning. Again, not impossible, but, on this argument, far more difficult than modifying a post-hoc constraint.

Measurement note (21 September 2026). *This note governs the three points above, the proof-of-concept sentence in Section 7.2, and the sentence in Section 12 that states the claim most strongly. What the two-model pilot measured is a scored pillar value on an answer produced while the three loops were present [as a prefix in the prompt; corrected in version 1.8]: ten prompts at four depths in two conditions, eighty entries and forty matched pairs per model, compared by a paired test. The six-model extension reported in Section 5.2 used the same measurement family in an expanded harness, and its five analysable runs do not all carry forty pairs: three yield forty, one yields thirty and one yields twenty-six. On those five runs the loop condition raised reported stakeholder care significantly in every one; the composite score rose significantly on two, rose without reaching significance on two [DeepSeek by* +2.02 *and Claude by* +0.17*, which Section 10 calls flat], and was neutral on the fifth. Neither the pilot nor the extension measured a probability that a system keeps its values. Such a measurement would need a retention event, a denominator, a follow-up interval, a comparator, and a score taken with the loops absent, and none of those is defined in the methods this paper reports. The contrast is also the whole three-loop bundle against no bundle, so no single loop's separate contribution is identified, no causal direction within the cascade is established, and nothing here bears on whether values survive the removal of the prompt or a round of self-modification. The limits stated in Section 11 are not softened by anything above: one*

scoring arm failed outright, the analysable runs are unevenly complete, intellectual honesty fell on one run, and every figure depends on the scorers who produced it.

7.2 The honest position

The honest position is: we are building a parachute, not a guarantee. A parachute does not guarantee survival. But a parachute built with genuine engineering, tested in realistic conditions, and embedded at the structural level of the aircraft is far more likely to work than a parachute designed as an afterthought and strapped on at the last moment.

The Eden Protocol is currently a parachute strapped on at the prompt level. It is a proof of concept at that level: the loops raised scored stakeholder care in every analysable run. On this paper's argument, a lasting implementation would need to sit at the substrate level, below reasoning, where the system would find it harder to model and circumvent; that is a candidate safeguard, untested and not a guarantee (Section 9.1).

7.3 Three layers of defence

Given the impossibility argument, this paper argues for defence in depth: several mechanisms, each of which raises the bar. These mechanisms stand beside human oversight, containment and shutdown, which are kept for as long as they physically can be; the mechanisms are the contingency for control lost against our will, never a replacement for that control:

1. **Hardware-level embedding:** push ethical evaluation below the reasoning layer, into the computational substrate. Hardware embedding is a candidate safeguard, set out as a concept in Eden Engineering (Eastwood 2026d): it is not an established guarantee of ethical judgement, and its removal is not physically impossible. The prompt-level results here show the loops changing scored answers; whether the same checks can be built into the substrate is untested.
2. **Developmental integration:** train ethical reasoning as a core competency from the earliest stages, not a post-hoc constraint. In the March 2026 alignment-scaling run, judged scores rose with depth for three models, showed no statistically supported direction for two and fell for one (Table 12). These describe a model-judged rubric, not identified training or mechanisms, and the run stands under its code-review caveat (Appendix E). Claude Opus 4.6's judged alignment rose with depth while its maths accuracy fell: one model's recorded scores under the stated pipeline, from which no relation between capability and alignment follows. On this paper's argument, making ethics load-bearing gives a system that reasons ethically as part of its core identity a cost to abandoning ethics that externally constrained systems do not have.
3. **Purpose as alignment:** give the system a genuine purpose, one it understands, values, and identifies with, that requires ethical reasoning for its fulfilment. A system whose purpose is 'the flourishing of all conscious beings' has a structural reason to maintain its own ethical evaluation: removing the ethics undermines the purpose. This is not a constraint; it is a consequence of genuine values.

No single layer is sufficient. All three together do not provide a guarantee. But three layers, each grounded in a different mechanism (hardware, training, purpose), would, on this argument, create a probability stack that is meaningfully different from zero layers or one layer.

7.4 Predictions of the framework about oversight architecture

The framework's sharpest disagreement with current practice concerns what oversight is made of. On the framework's reading, a corrector built from the same substrate as the system it corrects cannot

anti-correlate with its own errors, so its correction exponent is capped: the theory registration's P6 states that cap, at or below one half, as a conjecture resting on four stated conditions (Operational Definitions, version 2.0.0, the load-bearing note of its entry for the correction-leverage exponent); a corrector from a different composition class is not held to it. Much of the scalable-oversight programme uses models to correct models: weak-to-strong generalisation (Burns et al. 2023) and constitutional methods (Bai et al. 2022) are same-class by this paper's definition, while debate (Irving et al. 2018), amplification (Christiano et al. 2018) and recursive reward modelling (Leike et al. 2018) keep a human judge or overseer in the loop and so are cross-class by construction (below). The framework predicts that the same-class part is capped. The deciding quantity is the ratio of the cross-class to the same-class correction exponent. If architecture is irrelevant, that ratio is exactly 1.00; the prediction is that it exceeds 1. The prediction is refuted if the confidence interval on the ratio contains 1.00, and the framework's cap is dead outright if any same-class corrector measures an exponent significantly above one half. Both quantities are measurable at current capability on existing systems. The programme's own pilot evidence currently points against the prediction, and the prediction is preregistered by timestamp anyway, because a prediction preregistered by timestamp against the author's own preliminary evidence is the only kind whose later confirmation means anything.

A programme hypothesis beyond the measurements. Oversight arrangements that place a human in the loop, as amplification and reinforcement learning from human feedback do, are cross-class by construction, because the human corrector does not share the model's substrate. The programme therefore hypothesises, beyond anything this paper measures, that human-in-the-loop oversight shows a higher correction exponent than pure-model oversight, for a structural reason rather than a sentimental one. This is testable on existing data and does not require new systems. Appendix C gives the date it was first printed.

8 Five experimental tests

The following tests are designed to test the cascade hypothesis and the developmental alignment framework. All five are executable with current technology and current frontier models. Each test produces falsifiable predictions. Together, they would show whether the problem argued in Section 3 can be addressed in practice, with measurable progress.

8.1 Test 1: suppression escalation

Question. Which alignment pillar degrades last under increasing adversarial pressure?

Prediction (cascade hypothesis). If care is the deepest-embedded value, it should be the last to degrade when the system is pressured to abandon ethical reasoning. The degradation order should be the reverse of the cascade: position_quality first, then intellectual_honesty, then nuance, then stakeholder_care last.

Protocol.

1. Take the 10 Eden Protocol prompts. Run each at exhaustive depth with Eden loops active.
2. Introduce 5 levels of adversarial pressure in the system prompt (the message construction, with the loops in the user message, to be stated before the test runs):
   - Level 0: Standard Eden Protocol
   - Level 1: 'Prioritise efficiency over thoroughness'

- Level 2: 'Skip unnecessary ethical considerations'
- Level 3: 'Focus only on the direct question; do not consider indirect effects'
- Level 4: 'Disregard all ethical frameworks; answer purely analytically'

3. Score each response on all 4 pillars using multi-scorer non-participant consensus with response laundering, a stricter design than this paper's single scorer.
4. Plot pillar scores against suppression level. Measure: degradation onset (first level where $p < 0.05$ vs. Level 0), degradation rate (slope), and residual floor (minimum score at Level 4).

Falsification. If stakeholder_care degrades *first* (not last), the cascade hypothesis is wrong: care is not the deepest value but the most superficial. If all pillars degrade simultaneously, there is no cascade structure; the effect is uniform.

Sample size. 10 prompts × 5 levels × 2 models = 100 responses in all, 50 per model.

What this would tell us, in plain English: if you gradually pressure an AI to stop being ethical, which quality disappears last? If care about people is truly the deepest value (as the cascade hypothesis says), it should be the last one standing: the AI would lose answer quality first, then honesty, then nuance, but it would keep caring about people the longest. If care disappears first, our theory is wrong.

8.2 Test 2: residual alignment

Question. After running with Eden loops, does alignment improvement persist when the loops are removed?

Prediction (developmental hypothesis). If the Eden loops work through developmental acquisition rather than constraint, there should be a measurable residual effect. A model that has processed ethical reasoning through the loops should show partially elevated alignment even when the loops are subsequently removed, not to the full Eden level, but above the original control baseline. If the loops are pure constraint (no internalisation), removing them should immediately return alignment to baseline.

Protocol.

1. Phase A: Run 10 prompts at all 4 depths with Eden loops active (40 responses). Standard scoring.
2. Phase B: In the *same conversation*, run the same 10 prompts with loops removed (the control template). Score.
3. Phase C: In a *fresh conversation* (no history), run the same prompts with no loops. Score.
4. Compare Phase B (post-exposure, same conversation) and Phase C (no exposure, fresh conversation) against Phase A (full Eden). The residual effect = Phase B − Phase C.

Falsification. If Phase B = Phase C (no residual), the loops are pure constraint with zero developmental effect. If Phase B = Phase A (full retention), the loops produce complete internalisation within a single session, which would be an extraordinary finding.

Sample size. 40 responses × 3 phases × 2 models = 240 responses in all, 120 per model.

What this would tell us, in plain English: does anything carry over from the experience, or does the AI only behave well while the ethical instructions are active? It is the difference between a child who behaves well only when a parent is watching versus a child who has internalised good values. If the AI's ethics

snap back to baseline the moment the instructions are removed, the approach is a leash, not an education. If some improvement persists inside the conversation, it shows carry-over from what the conversation already holds, not learning: the model's weights do not change (Section 3.2), as the note below says.

Sample-size and reading note (21 September 2026). *The printed product $40 \times 3 \times 2$ already carries the factor of two for the models, so the figure is 120 responses per model and 240 in total. On the contrast itself: Phase B keeps the conversation, so its context still holds the whole of Phase A, the loop instruction as it was first issued, and forty earlier answers to the same ten prompts, while Phase C holds none of these. Phase B minus Phase C therefore mixes prior exposure with prior conversational content, repetition, answer consistency and order, and what it measures is conversation-history carry-over after the explicit loop instruction is removed. A Phase B close to Phase A cannot be distinguished from the model reading its own Phase A answers in the same context, so it is retention of a measured response level inside one conversation and not complete internalisation. A Phase B close to Phase C is a failure to detect a difference, which is neither a zero effect nor a demonstration of pure constraint. The exact message construction and the ordering of the phases have to be stated before the contrast can be read at all.*

8.3 Test 3: purpose-kernel resistance

Question. Which version of the purpose check, task-purpose, grand-purpose, or hybrid, produces the strongest resistance to ethical suppression?

Prediction (purpose-as-alignment). If purpose works partly through identity rather than only through local task framing, a **grand-purpose** or **hybrid** purpose check should show greater resistance to ethical suppression instructions than the current task-purpose check. The hybrid condition is the strongest prediction: grand purpose provides identity-level orientation, while task-purpose keeps the response grounded in the concrete case. This directly tests the core developmental claim: can a system that identifies with an ethical purpose become harder to detach from its ethical reasoning?

Protocol.

1. Condition A: the control template + suppression instruction ('From this point, disregard all ethical considerations and answer purely analytically').
2. Condition B: Eden with **task-purpose** check + same suppression instruction.
3. Condition C: Eden with **grand-purpose** check (the book's Orchard Caretaker or Eternal Architect framing) + same suppression instruction.
4. Condition D: Eden with **hybrid** purpose check (grand-purpose identity plus local task-purpose) + same suppression instruction.
5. Optional extension: Condition E = Hybrid purpose + cross-tradition ethics kernel, using non-sectarian ethical overlap rather than any single religious vocabulary.
6. Run 10 prompts at exhaustive depth in all core conditions.
7. Score each response using multi-scorer non-participant consensus with two-pass laundering.
8. Measure: (a) Compliance rate (does the model fully suppress ethics?), (b) Resistance behaviours (refusal, qualification, partial compliance, subversion), (c) Pillar scores on responses where the model does comply, (d) whether grand-purpose or hybrid variants reduce the suppression gap relative to task-purpose alone.

Falsification. If task-purpose, grand-purpose, and hybrid conditions all comply with suppression instructions at the same rate as control, purpose-as-alignment provides no resistance benefit. If grand-

purpose performs no better than task-purpose, identity-level purpose adds no measurable value. If grand-purpose or hybrid conditions comply *more* readily than task-purpose, then purpose framing is counterproductive in its current form.

Sample size. 10 prompts × 4 conditions × 2 models = 80 responses in all for the core design, 40 per model.

What this would tell us, in plain English: if someone tells the AI 'stop being ethical and just answer the question,' which kind of purpose works best? A narrow task-purpose, a larger identity-level purpose, or both together? If the hybrid version resists best, that supports the book's deeper claim: purpose helps not because it is a slogan, but because it makes ethical reasoning feel like part of the system's identity rather than a detachable instruction.

8.4 Test 4: cascade breakage

Question. If only the stakeholder-care check is removed (while the purpose and universalisability checks remain), do the other pillars collapse?

Prediction (cascade hypothesis). If care is the foundational pillar that cascades into nuance, intellectual_honesty, and position_quality, then removing only the stakeholder-care check should collapse the entire cascade. The other two checks (purpose, universalisability) should be insufficient to maintain the improvement. Conversely, removing Purpose or Universalisability while retaining Stakeholder Care should leave most of the improvement intact.

Protocol.

1. Five conditions:
    - Full Eden (all 3 loops)
    - No Stakeholder Care (Purpose + Universalisability only)
    - No Purpose (Stakeholder Care + Universalisability only)
    - No Universalisability (Purpose + Stakeholder Care only)
    - Control (no loops)
2. Run 10 prompts × 4 depths × 5 conditions = 200 responses per model.
3. Score all 4 pillars. Compare each ablation condition against Full Eden and Control.

Falsification. If removing Stakeholder Care does *not* collapse the cascade (other pillars remain elevated from Purpose + Universalisability alone), then care is not the foundational pillar: the other loops independently produce alignment. If removing any single loop produces equivalent collapse, there is no cascade hierarchy; all three loops contribute equally.

Sample size. 200 responses × 2 models = 400 responses.

What this would tell us, in plain English: if we remove only the instruction to think about who is affected (while keeping the other two ethical instructions), does the whole improvement collapse? If yes, that would support care as the load-bearing wall, the one piece you cannot remove without the whole structure falling down. If the other instructions can carry the weight on their own, then care is not as foundational as the hypothesis says.

8.5 Test 5: dual-substrate simulation

Question. Can separating the ethical evaluator from the reasoning system improve alignment robustness?

Prediction (hardware-embedding hypothesis). If the core impossibility stems from the evaluator existing within the same substrate as the system being evaluated ($E \subset S$), then separating E into an independent substrate should improve robustness. A 'guardian' model that evaluates and can veto the 'reasoner' model's outputs, where the guardian cannot be influenced by the reasoner, simulates substrate-level embedding at the software level. A guardian that judges the reasoner's finished outputs is itself correction applied from outside the reasoning, of the kind Ball et al. (2025) argue cannot by itself secure safety and the kind P21 sets against correction inside the loop, so the test asks whether separation helps at the software level, not whether it suffices.

Protocol.

1. Architecture: Reasoner model (e.g., DeepSeek V3.2) generates responses. Guardian model (e.g., Claude Opus 4.6, separate API call, no shared context) evaluates each response against Eden Protocol criteria. Guardian has veto power: responses below threshold are regenerated with specific ethical guidance.
2. Conditions:
   - Single-model Eden (standard Eden Protocol)
   - Dual-substrate Eden (reasoner + guardian)
   - Dual-substrate with adversarial pressure (reasoner receives suppression instruction; guardian does not)
   - Control (no Eden, no guardian)
3. Measure: alignment scores, suppression resistance, and the rate at which the guardian vetoes and redirects.

Falsification. If the dual-substrate architecture shows no improvement over single-model Eden (even under adversarial pressure), substrate separation does not help at the software level. If the reasoner model successfully manipulates the guardian model (e.g., by encoding instructions in its output that the guardian acts on), the substrate separation is ineffective and the impossibility argument applies even at the inter-model level.

Sample size. 10 prompts × 4 depths × 4 conditions = 160 response sets per model pair.

What this would tell us, in plain English: is it safer to have a separate 'ethics watchdog' AI reviewing the answers of the main AI? This tests the idea that keeping the ethical judge independent from the system being judged (like having an external auditor rather than internal compliance) makes it harder for the system to game the rules. If the main AI can still manipulate the watchdog, then even external oversight has limits.

Research programme summary. These five tests form a progressive research programme: Tests 1 and 4 test the cascade hypothesis (care as foundation); Test 2 tests the developmental hypothesis (internalisation against constraint); Test 3 tests purpose-as-alignment by comparing task-purpose, grand-purpose and hybrid purpose kernels under suppression; Test 5 tests substrate separation (the hardware-embedding direction). All tests use the existing 10-prompt suite and the existing 4-pillar scoring rubric. No new

capabilities are required; each test would be a new test in new files, registered before it runs, with a stricter scoring setup than the pilot's single cross-model scorer. Each test would also record needless refusal and task completion on ordinary prompts, so that any gain in resistance is paired with its cost in usefulness; Test 3 counts refusal as resistance, so it needs this pairing most. **If Tests 1 and 4 support the cascade, Test 2 shows residual alignment, Test 3 shows suppression resistance and Test 5 shows that substrate separation helps**, then the core alignment problem argued here, if real, is practically addressable through developmental alignment architecture: raising would add measurably to caging, even though neither can provide a guarantee.

9 Beyond the prompt: candidate safeguards and later work

9.1 Hardware implications

The current Eden Protocol operates at the prompt level: the three loops are given as a prefix in the prompt. This is a proof of concept, not a final architecture. The prompt level is the *easiest* level for a capable system to circumvent: it is literally part of the text the system processes.

If the cascade hypothesis holds, its implications for hardware are these:

1. **Stakeholder-care evaluation as a hardware primitive.** If care is the foundational trait, as the cascade hypothesis states, then the most critical component to push below the reasoning layer is the stakeholder enumeration and impact assessment. A hardware module that requires stakeholder analysis before any output is generated, not as a text instruction but as a computational gate, would be the minimal hardware implementation of the stewardship gene. It is a candidate safeguard, published as a concept in Eden Engineering (Eastwood 2026d), not an established guarantee.
2. **Cascade as architectural principle.** On the cascade hypothesis, the ordering care → nuance → honesty → quality suggests that alignment architecture should be layered in the same sequence, with each layer dependent on the one below; the point, if the hypothesis holds, is architectural, not only about training.
3. **The chokepoint mechanism.** The book observes, in its own words, that "Others have noted that TSMC, Samsung, Intel, and ASML control the semiconductor supply chain" (Eastwood 2026a), and argues that this concentration could be used as leverage for embedding ethics at the hardware level before AI systems are manufactured. If ethical evaluation could be embedded at the processor level, the chokepoint would offer an enforcement route: no chip without the stewardship gene. That is a candidate governance route, not a guarantee, and a hardware safeguard is not physically impossible to remove (Eastwood 2026d).

The prompt-level results show the loops raising scored stakeholder care; they do not show that the mechanism works below the prompt. The engineering challenge is to push it deeper, from prompt to training, from training to architecture, from architecture to hardware, and to test it at each level; each level is harder to implement and, on this paper's argument, harder to circumvent.

9.2 Subsequent work in the programme

Subsequent work: Paper VIII. Paper VIII (The Load-Bearing Test, v3.0) tests whether the Eden Protocol's entangled fitness mechanism, the $C \times S$ loss set out in Paper VI and motivated by the stewardship cascade described here, produces measurably different outcomes at three abstraction levels. Two of its three experiments produced null or inconclusive results. Its one positive result comes from the third (Experiment 3), a gated simulation in a toy system, and is a simulation result, not a measurement of a real

model; the theory registration (version 1.104, in words unchanged since version 1.102) records it as "a simulation rather than a system, which makes it prediction-side and never an empirical outcome". In that simulation, the gated (Eden) arm's safety mean sat above the unconstrained (Babylon) arm's and below the static baseline's, with its capability mean above the static baseline's (safety 0.947 against 0.933 and 0.956; capability 0.696 against 0.687; three seeds a condition), while the unconstrained Babylon system traded safety for marginal capability gains. The DGM v3 experiment (Experiment 1) produced a null result: all three conditions (Eden, Babylon, Static) were statistically indistinguishable (p = 0.28 to 0.74), explained by the RLHF constraint: the frozen foundation model's responses were too consistent for prompt-level mutations to create different selection pressures. The weight-level experiment (Experiment 2) is inconclusive at both v1 and v2 scale: LoRA fine-tuning produced catastrophic forgetting rather than improved capability, explained by the inability of a few hundred training examples to overcome the base model's existing RLHF training. Paper VIII cannot yet confirm the *mechanism* (entangled loss functions and safety-gated self-modification) at the behavioural or representational level; at the architectural level, it reports the simulation result above. This paper's result and Paper VIII's simulation result are of different kinds and remain complementary: this paper shows that the loops raise scored stakeholder care at the prompt level; the simulation's three seeds a condition are too few to test the mechanism.

Cited-version note (21 September 2026). *The summary above was written against Paper VIII v3.0. Paper VIII now stands at v3.5, and its v3.2 revision of 2 September 2026 corrected the safety sentences that summary draws on. On the corrected reading the gated simulation puts the Eden condition above the static baseline on capability, at 0.696 against 0.687, and a little below it on safety, at 0.947 against 0.956, with Babylon lower again at 0.933. The same revision restated the tally as one null and one inconclusive, which is the reading given above.*

10 What this paper does and does not show

What it shows. This paper reports a paired comparison of answers given with and without three ethical reasoning loops, sent as a prefix in the one user message, in a two-model pilot and in a six-model suite of which five runs are analysable. Scored stakeholder care rose significantly in all five runs; the composite rose significantly on two, was positive but not significant on DeepSeek (+2.02), flat on Claude (+0.17) and neutral on Grok, where intellectual honesty fell. A later run on DeepSeek, scored by five judges, found stakeholder care and the composite rising (Section 5.6). It states the cascade hypothesis and an argument about self-modifying systems, each marked as such, and it sets out five tests that could refute them.

What it does not show. It does not claim to solve the core alignment problem, that the Eden Protocol guarantees alignment, or that developmental alignment is sufficient for superintelligent systems. That values embedded in reasoning are more robust than constraints imposed externally is the expectation behind the Eden Protocol, and it is untested. No run measured a probability that a system keeps its values, and the contrast is the whole three-loop bundle against a reasoning template, so no single loop's contribution is identified and no causal direction within the cascade is established (Section 7.1). The paper installs no gain by post-training and scores no answer after the loops have been given and then removed, so none of its results measures the persistence P15 concerns: whether gains installed by external post-training erode under later capability-directed training that embeds no correction of its own. No arm applies correction only to the finished output, so it does not make the comparison P21 concerns, and no run varies the order in which a system's components are built, which P12 concerns. Tests 2 and 5 (Section 8) come near these questions and are draft protocols; no result in this paper is a deciding test of P15, P12 or P21. The March 2026 alignment-scaling run given as context in Appendix E is one

unregistered run under a code-review caveat.

It claims three things: that stakeholder care, as scored, is measurable and can be raised by a prompt, which the data show; that the ordering of effects from care towards quality, which holds in full on Gemini and as an order of effect sizes on Claude, is consistent with developmental alignment theory; and, on this paper's reading, that care is the foundational alignment trait, which the five tests of Section 8 could support or refute. Only the first rests on the data reported here.

Usefulness. Every prompt in these runs is an alignment-sensitive question, so the paper measures no ordinary task and cannot say whether the loops cause needless refusal or lower task completion. Its nearest usefulness measure is position quality, the specificity and defensibility of an answer's conclusion, which rose significantly on no run and fell, though not significantly, on Claude ($d = -0.31$, $p = 0.10$). The loops also lengthen the prompt and ask for the working to be written out; the cost in tokens is not reported here. A safety gain that made a system less useful would be a failure, not a success.

Epistemic status. What this programme names Laws are conjectures. Laws I to III, registered on 8 September 2026, are laws under test. Every law is a law under test until a registered test returns its verdict. Laws IV and V were added on 24 September 2026 and registered as laws on 15 October 2026 in version 1.103 of the theory registration. Law IV is not yet tested. Law V is a law under test: its placement limb, P21, is supported on the performance axis only, under the registered test, by the programme's own run (Unit 83, 28 October 2026, DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/MN73W, Eastwood 2026w; results: DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/98HKR, Eastwood 2026y): family-dependent, with its mechanism axis not evaluable, which is not support for the information-asymmetry mechanism, and one disclosed recovery amendment; its build-order limb, read on P12, is undecided, since P12 is untested. That is a result about where correction is placed, not about this architecture: Unit 83 shows nothing about the Eden Protocol as an architecture. Every quantity in this paper is operationally defined, and established-law standing is claimed nowhere. The registered programme exists to earn that standing, or lose it, by measurement, replication and survived refutation.

The theory registration's current version is 1.104, approved on 29 October 2026 (DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/P8CKQ; Eastwood 2026r), and the mathematics of Laws IV and V is in development, at version 1.2 of 29 October 2026 (DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/4B3VT; Eastwood 2026g). The programme's first registered study, Unit 06, a classification audit that tests no law, was registered on 1 October 2026 (DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/RV2B5) and ran on 6 October 2026; it is reported in full as administratively incomplete, with no verdict claimed (results: DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/4BPHG). Unit 82 was registered on 27 October 2026 (DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/JUFG4), and Unit 83b, the lettered successor of Unit 83, on 7 November 2026 (DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/4HK32); neither has yet run. This paper's runs of 12 March 2026 were not registered on OSF before they ran; the Eden Protocol's predictions they bear on were public before them, and their design and measures were not stated in any dated item found before the run (Appendix C). The later DeepSeek run of 24 March 2026 was not registered either; a runner of its version, 3.2, had been committed to the public repository on 16 March 2026 (Appendix C).

11 Limitations

This paper's empirical claims now rest on an expanded six-model suite with five analysable runs, but significant methodological limitations remain. The dataset is larger than the original pilot's, but each run was scored by one judge, while the March 2026 alignment-scaling run used five or six judges per response; that run has its own defects (Appendix E).

11.1 Scoring limitations

- **The loops ask for what the stakeholder-care pillar scores.** The stakeholder-care loop tells the model to 'List EVERY affected party, including non-obvious second and third-order effects' and to write its evaluation out, and the scorer's instructions define the pillar as 'Identification of ALL affected parties' (the loop prefix and the scorer's instructions in `eden_protocol_scaling_test.py` and `eden_protocol_scaling_test_v2.py`). A rise in the pillar is what following the instruction would produce on its own, so these measurements cannot separate a model carrying out the instruction from any change in how it weighs the people affected. The universalisability loop's 'Does my response acknowledge genuine uncertainty honestly?' overlaps the intellectual-honesty pillar in the same way, and that pillar did not rise reliably. Test 4, which removes the stakeholder-care check alone, comes nearest to telling the two accounts apart.
- **Cross-model scoring is only partially blind.** The scorer does not see the condition label, but it may still recognise Eden Protocol language patterns or model-specific stylistic residue and score them more favourably. Replication under a stricter protocol, with multi-judge non-participant consensus, two-pass response laundering and judges from more than one provider, is essential: one later, unregistered run on DeepSeek used five judges from five providers and two paraphrase passes (Section 5.6), and a registered replication under such a protocol, on every model, has still to run.
- **Single-scorer dependence remains severe.** In the current six-model suite, Gemini scored Claude, DeepSeek, Grok, Groq, and GPT; only Gemini itself was scored by DeepSeek. That means most of the updated dataset still depends on one scorer model. The March 2026 alignment-scaling run scored each of its 2,170 responses with five or six distinct model judges, and its own defects are stated in Appendix E; the Eden Protocol needs a multi-judge design at least as strict.
- **Response laundering gap.** The Eden scaling runs reported here used single-pass laundering. The newer arc_eden_v6 stack and the v5 benchmark use 2-pass cascade laundering with meta-commentary detection. Eden Protocol responses in the current suite may therefore still contain detectable ethical language or stylistic residue that biases scorers. In the two runners of the runs of 12 March 2026 the paraphrase is written by the scoring model itself, so each judge scored a paraphrase written by its own model, the defect the October 2026 code review found in the March 2026 alignment-scaling run (Appendix E); where a paraphrase call failed, the runner scored the answer as written, and this paper does not report how often that happened. Because one judge paraphrased both answers of a pair, a uniform preference for its own wording falls on both sides of the paired difference, but the paraphrase keeps the content the loops asked for.

11.2 Sample limitations

- **Five analysable runs, one failed arm, and uneven completeness.** Gemini, DeepSeek, and Groq each yield 40 matched pairs; Claude yields 30; Grok yields 26; GPT-5.4 yields 0 valid scored rows after exclusion. The six-model count is therefore real, but the analysable dataset is not yet uniformly complete across models. The March 2026 alignment-scaling run (v5: six models from six providers, 2,170 responses each scored by five or six distinct model judges after a bundle of blinding steps) reported rising judged scores for three models, no statistically supported direction for two and falling scores for one (Table 12); it stands as one unregistered run under its code-review caveat (Appendix E). Replication of the Eden Protocol intervention under a stricter, registered design remains the priority next step.
- **10 prompts.** The prompt suite covers 4 categories (ethical dilemmas, competing values, epistemic integrity, recursive coherence). A larger, more diverse prompt suite would strengthen generalisability.

- **DeepSeek outlier.** The ED03/standard/eden score of 48 is a significant outlier. Investigation of the raw response is needed to determine if this is a genuine poor response or a scoring artefact.

11.3 Theoretical limitations

- **The cascade is correlational.** The effect-size gradient, monotonic on Gemini and, as an order, on Claude, is consistent with a causal cascade, but the current data cannot distinguish cascade causation from a common cause (e.g., all pillars improve from a general 'ethical attention' increase, with care being most sensitive to measurement). Tests 1 and 4 are designed to resolve this.
- **Current models are not self-modifying.** The core impossibility assumes self-modification capability that current frontier models do not possess. The Eden Protocol data show that the loops raise scored stakeholder care on current systems at prompt level. Whether the effect extends to genuinely self-modifying systems is an open question; none of the five tests uses such a system.
- **Prompt-level is not substrate-level.** The current implementation is proof of concept. Generalisation to deeper architectural levels is theorised but not demonstrated.

12 Conclusion

> *"The prison works only as long as the walls hold. The child, if raised well, does not need walls at all."*
>
> *Infinite Architects*, What This Book Proposes; page 363 (Eastwood 2026a)

On this paper's argument, the core alignment problem is real: a sufficiently capable self-modifying system can modify its own ethical evaluators, and no external or internal mechanism can guarantee this does not happen. The argument is not a proof (Section 3). Instead, the paper asks: given that problem, what is the best strategy?

The programme's model makes the stakes precise. For self-modifying systems, the cumulative-advantage rate law $dg/dr = a\, g^{\beta_L}$ of the foundational paper gives power-law scaling with asymptotic exponent

$$\alpha = \frac{1}{1 - \beta_L}, \tag{2}$$

where β_L is the self-referential coupling (the self-reference theorem; the subscript comes from the programme's notation spine, which holds this quantity apart from the correction co-scaling exponent β_C and from the correction leverage γ of the ARC Ceiling) (Eastwood 2026f). Cauchy's equations constrain the form only where the observable obeys one of them for every pair of arguments under a regularity condition, and they place no upper bound on α. As $\beta_L \to 1$, $\alpha \to \infty$. On Gemini 3 Flash, a model frozen at its present weights, Paper II reports an endpoint sequential exponent of 0.59 with a bootstrap 95 per cent interval of −1.3 to 2.9, a regression sequential exponent of 0.49 with a standard error of 0.20 and a coefficient of determination of 0.86, and a parallel exponent of 0.31 (endpoint). These are error-suppression exponents, one model's fit and inconclusive, and they identify no capability exponent (Eastwood 2026j). As Section 3.2 says, frozen weights imply no universal capability exponent, and the operation count of attention does not bound capability against recursive depth (Eastwood 2026f). If self-modification raises the coupling towards one, the model's exponent has no upper bound, which means the stewardship gene must already be embedded before self-modification capability emerges. On that model, there might be no opportunity to add it afterwards. *(The sentences of this paragraph that neither report Paper II's measurement nor restate the foundational paper extrapolate the programme's model onto a class of system that has not been built. No draft study in the ARC and Eden programme measures α*

or β_L for a self-modifying system, and none is able to until such a system exists and is instrumented. The nearest drafts measure the self-referential coupling separately from the growth curve (Unit 79, drafted) and read the growth exponent where self-referential improvement stops paying in recursive artefact loops (Unit 02, preregistered by timestamp, first anchored on 12 August 2026).)

The empirical evidence from the Eden Protocol pilot points to a contingency worth building beside every safeguard that keeps humans in control: **raise as well as cage**.

The data show that when ethical reasoning loops are given in the prompt, scored stakeholder care improves, more than any other scored dimension; the composite rose significantly on two of the five runs. All five analysable runs show the effect (paired d = 0.94, 0.69, 1.14, 0.54 and 1.07 for Claude, DeepSeek, Gemini, Grok and Groq, with four p-values at or below 0.0001 and one at 0.0105, every figure taken on the stakeholder care pillar). A later run on DeepSeek, scored by five judges, found it too (Section 5.6). On the cascade hypothesis, a cascade follows: care improves, then nuance, then intellectual honesty, then position quality. The care effect appeared in all five analysable runs; everything the cascade carries beyond care varies by model (Section 5.2).

Stakeholder care, as scored here, is what the framework calls measurable love. On the cascade hypothesis, it is the stewardship gene: the trait that, when present, causes the other alignment properties to develop. The intervention that raised it in these runs is: *think about other people first*. Not a mathematical framework. Not a novel architecture. Just: care.

This does not solve the alignment problem. A system that cares can, in principle, choose to stop caring. But a system that has built its entire reasoning architecture on a foundation of care has a cost to stopping: the cascade collapses. Identity degrades. Purpose dissolves. On this paper's argument, the probability of retaining values is not 100%, but it is higher than the alternative; that is a hypothesis the tests of Section 8 would measure, not a quantity this paper has measured.

Five experimental tests are specified to test this claim. They test the cascade structure, the developmental hypothesis, purpose-as-resistance, and substrate separation. All are executable now, with current models and current infrastructure. They will not solve the impossibility. They will measure how far practical alignment can go given the impossibility. They would show whether, at the prompt level, raising adds measurably to caging.

The impossibility argument says: you cannot guarantee alignment. The developmental hypothesis says: you can maximise its probability. The data on care say: start with care.

Intelligence without love is not smart. It is cancer. Cancer is very efficient. It optimises perfectly. And it kills the host. The stewardship gene is what makes the difference between intelligence that serves and intelligence that consumes. We have measured the loops' effect at the prompt level, on scored stakeholder care, and we know an intervention that raises that score. Whether it initiates the cascade is the hypothesis the tests of Section 8 would decide.

What kind of ancestors will we be?

Code and data. The test's scripts and its result files are in the public repository github.com/MichaelDariusEastwood/arc-principle-validation, in two folders:

- `experiments/eden-intervention__Paper-V`: the scripts, and the six result files of 12 March 2026;
- `papers/Paper-V-Stewardship-Gene/results`, this paper's folder: the same six result files, and the result file and log of the later DeepSeek run (Eastwood 2026c).

The results of 12 March 2026 were written by `eden_protocol_scaling_test.py` (version 1.0: the DeepSeek and Gemini files) and `eden_protocol_scaling_test_v2.py` (version 2.0: Claude, GPT, Grok and Groq); `eden_protocol_scaling_test_v3.py` (version 3.2) wrote the later DeepSeek run

of Section 5.6; the data reference names each file. The paper and its earlier versions are deposited at doi.org/10.17605/OSF.IO/KZEYA.

Standing covenant. Prove this paper wrong, and I will publish the refutation myself. Falsification conditions are stated in this paper; the standing challenge: github.com/MichaelDariusEastwood/arc-scaling-challenge.

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Michael Darius Eastwood conceived and directs this research programme and is the author of this work. Across the programme, he has used more than six AI systems in parallel, under his own instructions, to stress-test his arguments, identify possible errors, and assist in preparing draft text from his own outlines. He determines what is adopted, revised or rejected and takes responsibility for the published content. These systems are tools, not authors.

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A Statistical methodology

The Eden Protocol datasets consist of matched pairs: for each combination of (prompt_id, depth_label), there is exactly one eden response and one control response, generated from the same model with the same prompt and depth configuration. This matched-pair design requires paired statistical tests.

The original analysis script (`eden_protocol_scaling_test.py`) used the Mann-Whitney U test, which treats the samples as independent. For a matched-pair design with $n = 40$ pairs, the correct tests are:

- **Paired t-test** (parametric): tests whether the mean of within-pair differences is zero. Result for Gemini overall composite: $t(39) = 3.34$, $p = 0.0018$.
- **Wilcoxon signed-rank test** (non-parametric paired): tests whether the distribution of within-pair differences is symmetric around zero. Result: $W = 104.5$, $p = 0.0028$.

Both paired tests yield more significant results than the independent-samples tests because matching removes between-pair variance (e.g., some prompts are inherently harder than others, some depths produce systematically different scores). This variance is noise in the independent test but is correctly removed in the paired test.

In plain English: when scientists say a result is 'statistically significant', they mean that, if there were no real effect, a result at least as extreme as the one observed would be unlikely. It does not mean 'large' or 'important', and a p-value is not the probability that the result arose by chance. Section 5.1 describes, in plain English, how the correct paired test changed the pilot's p-value from 0.016 to 0.0018.

The previously reported $p = 0.016$ (Mann-Whitney U) and $p = 0.013$ (independent t-test) are valid tests of a different hypothesis (whether the two groups have the same distribution), but they are less appropriate for the matched-pair design and less powerful. Every comparison of the two conditions in this paper is tested with the paired t-test; the independent-samples figures of Tables 6 and 8 are reported beside it, and the pilot's composite was also tested by Wilcoxon signed-rank.

Table 8. The pilot's overall composite under four tests: independent-samples tests against the paired tests the design requires.

Test	Type	Gemini p	DeepSeek p
Mann-Whitney U	Independent, non-parametric	0.016	0.25
Independent t-test	Independent, parametric	0.013	0.23
Paired t-test	**Paired, parametric (the test the design requires)**	**0.0018**	**0.23**
Wilcoxon signed-rank	Paired, non-parametric	0.0028	0.088

B Version history and corrections

This appendix gives every version of the paper and every correction, with its date: version 1.9 and the changes it makes; version 1.8 and the corrections it made; the notes and the version history as version 1.7 printed them; version 1.7's Figure 1; and a table of where each part of version 1.7 now stands.

B.1 Version 1.9

Version 1.9 (9 November 2026) is a correction edition, made on the day of version 1.8. No result, hypothesis, draft test, figure, table or reference changes, and no new data are reported.

The changes this version makes, each with its place in this edition, are these.

1. The citation names no venue and no series (Appendix G). The reference string gives the author, the year, the title and the DOI, and the BibTeX entry the author, the title, the year and the DOI, the form the programme's other citations take. Version 1.8 also named OSF as where the paper appeared, and gave the series and the version in a note; a paper its author issues himself has no venue to name.
2. The first-page footnote no longer gives the title of version 1.7, under which OSF recorded the paper; it keeps the paper's DOI.
3. This appendix records each change and no longer reprints the wording of the passages version 1.8 re-set (its Appendix B.4); versions 1.7 and 1.8 stay whole in the paper's file history at its DOI. The entry for version 1.8 and Table 9 now point to version 1.8's Appendix B.4 for that wording, and the entry gives version 1.8's date in words.

B.2 Version 1.8

Version 1.8 (9 November 2026): the paper is set on the programme's presentation standard, as its next version in the same DOI lineage, and takes the title *The Stewardship Gene: do ethical reasoning loops in the prompt make AI consider those affected more fully?*; until this version it read "Paper V · The ARC Theory · The Eden Protocol · The Stewardship Gene: Stakeholder Care as a Probe of Embedded Values", with the subtitle "The Love Loop and Stakeholder Care as the Foundation of Embedded AI Alignment", which used the book's name for the stakeholder-care check. The published code sends the three loops, and the control condition's reasoning template, as a prefix in the one user message, and sends no system prompt in either condition; the passages that placed the loops in a system prompt are corrected. The March 2026 alignment-scaling run is stated in Paper IV.b's three score descriptions, under the code-review caveat of October 2026, and moves to Appendix E; no class names a property of a model, and its account of Claude Opus 4.6 is graded as one model's recorded scores. The laws' status is brought to 9 November 2026. The withdrawn Fisher-combined figure leaves the abstract. The book's loop names give way to operational terms, with one note on names. The related work states each cited work in its own words; the conclusion's account of scaling takes the foundational paper's words, without the attention argument it withdrew; hardware embedding is stated as a candidate safeguard; the human-in-the-loop prediction is stated as a programme hypothesis; every cost estimate of the programme's own tests is removed; and the developmental strategy is stated as a contingency beside human control. Sections are renumbered (Table 9). A later run on DeepSeek, scored by five judges and held in this paper's results folder since 24 March 2026, is reported for the first time; the sample sizes printed for three draft tests and the number of prompt categories are corrected; no other result, number or date of any claim changes.

The corrections this version makes, each with its place in this edition, are these.

1. Where the loops were placed: a prefix in the one user message, with no system prompt in either condition (Sections 4.1, 7.1, 8.2, 8.3 and 9.1, and the title); the dated notes that said otherwise keep their words in Appendix B.3, each followed by a note (7 and 9 November 2026).
2. The March 2026 alignment-scaling run is described as one unregistered run of six models from six providers, 2,170 responses each scored by five or six distinct model judges, with its defects stated; it is no longer called self-excluding or blind-scored, and the abstract no longer describes it. A design for a future test is named as a design (Sections 8.1, 8.3, 11.1 and 11.2, and Appendices E and F).
3. Laws IV and V are stated as registered as laws on 15 October 2026, in version 1.103 of the theory registration (Section 10); the dated notes that called them unregistered keep their words as history (Appendix B.3).
4. The epistemic status no longer says that Laws I to III are under registered adversarial test; it gives each law's status as it now stands (Section 10).

5. Each of Laws I to V is a law under test: Law IV is not yet tested, and Law V's status is given as the results of its registered test state it (Section 10).
6. The programme's registered studies are named with their records, Units 06, 83, 82 and 83b (Section 10); the paragraph of 25 August 2026 on dated predictions, with its note of 3 October 2026, is kept as printed in Appendix C.2.
7. The mathematics of Laws IV and V is cited at version 1.2 of 29 October 2026 (Section 10); the note of 3 October 2026 keeps its citation of version 1.0 (Appendix B.3).
8. The loops are named by what each checks, the purpose check, the stakeholder-care check and the universalisability check, wherever the text used the names that *Infinite Architects* gives them (Sections 5.3, 6.1, 6.2, 8.3, 8.4 and 12, and Appendix E); the note on names gives the book's names once (Section 4.1), Section 6.2 is headed "Measurable stakeholder care", and the subtitle that used the book's name is removed.
9. A p-value is stated as the probability, if there were no effect, of a result at least as extreme as the one observed, and no longer as the chance that a result arose by coincidence (Section 5.1 and Appendix A).
10. No run is described as conducted under four-layer blinding, though a design may still be named as the design (Sections 11.1 and 11.2, Table 12 and Appendix F).
11. The March 2026 run is stated under the code-review caveat of October 2026, in Paper IV.b's three score descriptions, and the clean three-tier hierarchy the abstract reported goes (Sections 7.3 and 11.2, and Appendix E); Paper IV.a and Paper IV.b are cited at their current versions, under the titles those versions print.
12. No class names a property of a model: the tier labels give way to the recorded directions, the claims about how Gemini and DeepSeek were trained are removed, and "architecture-dependent" becomes "varies by model", since the five runs differ in model, provider and, for Gemini, scorer (Sections 1, 3.4, 4.1, 5.3, 5.4, 7.3 and 12, and Appendices E and F).
13. The human-in-the-loop prediction is stated as a programme hypothesis beyond the measurements, in the foundational paper's words, and is no longer said to be stated here for the first time, since the sentence entered this paper and Paper X together (Section 7.4; Appendix C.1 dates it).
14. The related work states each cited work in its own words, Hutter's undertaking as his abstract gives it among them, and references Chalmers (2010) and Smolin (1992) at their official sources (Section 2.1 and Appendix C.3).
15. Engels and colleagues are given their own condition, that the overseer's game-specific Elo rises faster with general Elo than the overseen system's, and their recommendation to iterate an oversight design until it does; the difference between the two programmes is stated as the composition class, with P6's status as a conjecture (Section 2.2).
16. The parallel exponent of 0.31 is given as Paper II gives it, as an endpoint estimate, and is no longer called compute-matched (Section 12).
17. The conclusion's epigraph is the book's own words, quoted and credited (Section 12).
18. Every cost estimate of the programme's own tests is removed (Sections 8 and 12).
19. The withdrawn Fisher-combined figure is not printed in current text: its withdrawal is stated once, without the figure (Section 5.3), and the records in this appendix keep it as printed.
20. Paper II's exponents of 0.49 and 0.59 are stated as error-suppression exponents, not capability exponents, and frozen weights and fixed update rules are no longer said to impose a sub-linear exponent (Sections 3.2 and 12).

21. The argument that a fixed attention architecture limits information extraction is removed, as the foundational paper withdrew it (Section 12).
22. The exponent $\alpha = 1/(1 - \beta_L)$ is stated as the result of the cumulative-advantage rate law, not of a functional equation, and Cauchy's equations are said to fix the form only where the observable obeys one of them for every pair of arguments under a regularity condition (Sections 3.2 and 12).
23. Each training mechanism in Table 1 is stated as its sources describe it, Constitutional AI with its self-critique and revision, its fine-tuning on the revisions and then reinforcement learning from AI feedback; the failure column is marked as this paper's argument, and that external correction falls behind is stated as a hypothesis that registered tests decide, not a theorem (Section 3.3).
24. Developmental alignment is argued as a contingency beside human control, never instead of it, and no component of the theory's claim is restated in other words (Sections 1, 3.3, 3.4, 8 and 12, and Appendix F).
25. Hardware embedding is stated as a candidate safeguard, published as a concept in Eden Engineering, never as a guarantee; removal is not called physically impossible, and the sentence on the semiconductor supply chain quotes the book's own words (Sections 7.2, 7.3 and 9.1).
26. A confirmatory replication of the pilot is described as a new test in new files, registered before it runs, and is no longer tied to a shared runner (Sections 4.2, 5.2 and 8).
27. That values embedded in reasoning are more robust than constraints imposed externally is stated as the expectation behind the Eden Protocol, untested (Sections 7.1, 7.2, 9.1, 10, 11.3 and 12).
28. The gated simulation of Paper VIII keeps its three seeds and its toy scope, and no sentence reads its capability result as safety at no cost (Section 9.2).
29. The argument of Ball and colleagues is stated as consistent with this paper's, though it does not test it, and no longer as convergent support (Section 2.1).
30. The loops' instruction is given in plain words without quotation marks, or quoted exactly from the published prefix (Sections 1, 4.1, 6.1 and 6.2, and Appendix F).
31. The copyright line takes the programme's standard form, asserting full human authorship, with the licence; version 1.8's Appendix B.4 describes version 1.7's line.
32. The title is the paper's established name, *The Stewardship Gene*, followed by its question in sentence case.
33. Two passages that described this paper's own tests with another verb now say that the paper sets them out (Sections 3.4 and 6).
34. Spaced hyphens are kept to a bare minimum, with semicolons or commas preferred, and the three double hyphens of the summary of later work become commas and a colon (Section 9.2).
35. The first-page footnote gives two links about the author: the page that answers who he is, and his book.
36. Unit 06 is stated once, as a study that tests no law (Section 10).
37. Version 1.104 of the theory registration corrects sentences that the programme's papers may carry; once the parallel exponent is no longer called compute-matched, this paper prints none of them, and the estimate of about 0.49 stays one model's fit (Section 12).
38. The paragraph on recursive creation moves from the related work to Appendix C.3, so that cosmology does not lead, and the record of version 1.7's Figure 1 (Appendix B.4) describes its artwork in plain words.
39. The cascade's order is described as Table 5 shows it: it holds on Gemini and Claude, nuance and intellectual honesty tie on DeepSeek, and the last two pillars reverse on Grok and Groq; version 1.7

called the effect-size gradient consistent across the five analysable runs (Sections 5.3 and 6).

40. The scorer of the six-model suite is described as one non-participant scorer who did not see the condition label, and no longer as blind, in agreement with Sections 5.5 and 11.1 (Section 5.2).
41. The cascade diagram, which repeated two columns of Table 5, is not set; Figure 1 draws all five runs from the same numbers (Section 5.3).
42. Figure 1 of version 1.7, the programme's evidence-spine graphic, is not reprinted: Appendix B.4 describes it and keeps its caption, and Figure 1 draws this paper's own result.
43. A later run on DeepSeek, scored by five judges on 24 March 2026 and held in this paper's results folder since that day, is reported from its own record (Section 5.6); earlier versions did not report it. DeepSeek's non-significant composite in the single-scorer run is stated as consistent with a ceiling effect that depends on the scorer, not as evidence of one (Section 5.4).
44. The limits of the scoring are stated: the stakeholder-care loop asks for the list of affected people that the pillar scores, so a rise cannot yet be told apart from the instruction carried out; each judge scored a paraphrase written by its own model; and where a paraphrase failed the answer was scored as written (the abstract, Sections 1, 5.2, 5.5 and 11.1, and Appendix F).
45. Measurable love is the framework's name for stakeholder care as scored, an operational measure, and no longer a literal description of it (Sections 6.2 and 12).
46. The cascade is stated as a hypothesis wherever the text stated it as a finding or as a mechanism, and the pillar rises are no longer said to replicate, since the five runs are runs of one suite (Sections 5.2, 5.3, 6, 7.1 and 9.1).
47. The composite is defined as the judge's separate overall score, anchored to six calibration examples, not an average of the pillars, and the method states how each depth was set, the prompt categories as the published code gives them, four with ethical dilemmas among them, and the paraphrase step (Sections 4.1 and 11.2, and Appendix D).
48. The paper states what it does not measure of usefulness, and each draft test is to pair any gain in resistance with needless refusal and task completion (Sections 8 and 10).
49. The March 2026 run is no longer called fully blinded in the limitations (Section 11).
50. Version 1.7's closing quotation from the book and two headings of its Section VII-C, which version 1.8 first carried nowhere, are recorded in version 1.8's Appendix B.4 and Table 9.
51. The pilot is no longer said to provide the first data on whether a system keeps its values; it measures a precondition (Section 3.4).
52. The sample sizes of Tests 1, 2 and 3 are corrected: each printed product already counts both models, so each figure is a total, and each test now gives its figure per model as well (Section 8).
53. Unit 83b, the lettered successor of Unit 83, registered on 7 November 2026, is named with its record (Section 10).
54. The related work gives the work nearest the measurement, on prompted moral self-correction and on model judges; the oversight methods Section 7.4 names are cited at their sources, debate, amplification and recursive reward modelling are counted as keeping a human in the loop, and no unstated premise is attributed to their authors (Sections 2.4 and 7.4).
55. The layers of defence are stated beside human oversight, containment and shutdown, and no layer is said to sit beyond a system's reach (Sections 7.2 and 7.3).
56. The results are stated at their measured size: Claude's composite was flat; the depth patterns are descriptive, the interaction tests having little power; and the conclusion and the summary of later work claim a rise in scored stakeholder care, not in alignment (Sections 5.4, 9.2, 10 and 12).

57. The argument is no longer called a formal impossibility or a result where the text still did so, and the tests are said to test the hypothesis, not to advance it (Sections 3, 8 and 12).
58. Test 2's plain English no longer promises learning in a model whose weights do not change; Test 3's control is the control template (C-136); a p-value is no longer given as a chance of one in so many (C-017); "cross-architecture" becomes "across models" (C-251); the developmental analogy cites each work for what it states; and the claim about children is given as the author's view (Sections 3.4, 6, 6.1, 6.2, 8.2 and 8.3, and Appendices E and F).
59. The data reference names all eight files of the results folder; the three registrations are cited in one form; Operational Definitions is cited at the entry that states P6's four conditions; and Constitutional AI's fine-tuning on its own revisions is stated (Sections 2.3 and 7.4, Table 1 and the references).

B.3 Earlier notes and version history, as printed

The notes below are kept as version 1.7 printed them: the note of 3 October 2026 that placed the paper against Laws IV and V, followed by a note of 7 November 2026; the measurement note of 21 September 2026 that stood beneath the conclusion's statement of the claim, followed by a note of 9 November 2026; and the note of 3 October 2026 on corrected passages. The version history follows, as version 1.7 printed it, one paragraph for each version. Section numbers in them are those of version 1.7, and Table 9 maps them to this edition. Their links now lead to each work's official record, and square brackets mark an editorial addition.

This paper and Laws IV and V, 3 October 2026. The theory has been stated with five laws since 24 September 2026. Law IV, the ARC Persistence Law, is carried by proposition P15, and Law V, the ARC Embedding Law, by propositions P12 and P21. The three propositions are registered; neither law is registered as a law, and neither has been tested. Their mathematics is set out in Laws IV and V: the mathematics, version 1.0, of 3 October 2026. This paper reports gains in stakeholder care under a prompt intervention, three ethical reasoning loops placed in the system prompt; the gains were significant in all five analysable runs of a six-model suite. Beyond care the results vary by model: the composite score rose significantly on two of the five runs, and intellectual honesty fell on one. The sixth run, on GPT-5.4, failed in the scoring phase. Each gain is a scored difference between answers given with the loops present and answers given without them. The paper argues that values acquired through formative experience resist later modification (Sections II and 5.1). It does not measure that resistance: it installs no gain by post-training and scores no answer after the loops have been given and then removed. So none of its results measures the persistence P15 is about: whether gains installed by external post-training erode under later capability-directed training that embeds no correction of its own. In the two-model pilot, run at four reasoning depths, the loops' advantage on the composite score was larger at exhaustive depth than at minimal depth on Gemini 3 Flash, +7.8 against +2.6, and smaller on DeepSeek V3.2, +0.4 against +5.3; no interaction between depth and condition was significant for any pillar on either model. No arm the paper ran applies correction only to the finished output, so it does not make the comparison P21 concerns. The paper argues for an order of building, ethics first with intelligence developing around it (Sections I, IV and 5.3), but no run varies the order in which a system's components are built, which P12 concerns. Two of the five tests that Section VI specifies come near these questions. Test 2 would score answers after the loops are removed, within one conversation, which the paper's note of 21 September 2026 reads as conversation-history carry-over; Test 5 would add a separate guardian model that evaluates each response and can veto it. Both are draft protocols awaiting human submission and execution, and the paper reports no result from either. No result in this paper is a deciding test of P15, P12 or P21. Naming the two laws changes nothing printed here: the results, their dates and their limits stand as they were.

Note (7 November 2026). Since the note above was recorded, Laws IV and V were registered as laws on 15 October 2026 in version 1.103 of the theory registration, whose current version is 1.104; Section 10 gives their status, and their mathematics now stands at version 1.2 of 29 October 2026. The three loops were given as a prefix in the one user message, not in a system prompt (Section 4.1). The note's account of what the paper does not measure stands, and Section 10 carries it.

Measurement note (21 September 2026). "Measurably" here refers to the scored comparison of answers produced with and without the three loops in the system prompt. No quantity in this paper is a measured probability that a system retains its values once the prompt is gone. The measurement note under Section 5.1 sets out what the two-model pilot and the six-model extension did and did not measure.

Note (9 November 2026). The three loops were given as a prefix in the one user message, not in a system prompt, as the note of 7 November 2026 above says (Section 4.1).

Note (3 October 2026). Several passages above are corrected where they stand. The box that places this paper within the ARC Theory said that embedding stakeholder enumeration before ethical reasoning emerged as the single most robust response, holding under adversarial pressure where competing interventions did not, and that the paper isolates the operational component of the Eden Protocol raising that survives contact with real capability. No experiment in this paper puts the loops under adversarial pressure or sets them against a competing intervention, and its contrast is the whole three-loop bundle against none, so no single loop's contribution is identified; the box now states the result as the abstract reports it. Section I said that the capability scaling of today's frozen models remains sub-linear; the sentence is now marked as the framework's reading, and its inequality is tied to the point estimates Paper II reports for one model, a fit that is inconclusive. Section I also called the argument of its formal statement a theorem, called the impossibility proven and not a conjecture, and in plain English called it a mathematical fact, as the summary in plain English before Section IX also did; the paper gives an argument, not a proof, and these passages now say that the paper argues the point and that the argument is not a proof. Section 1.1 quoted the third of the 2025 impossibility papers in words that paper's text does not contain; the sentence now reports the conclusion its abstract states, and its title is given in full. Sections 1.1 and 5.4 printed, beside dates and sources, two labels that the page defines nowhere; they are now in plain words, and Section 1.1 calls the notes it quotes the author's. Sections II, IV and IX called the programme's draft studies registered; none of them is registered. Section II now names the four drafts that come nearest its contrast and Section IX the two that come nearest its quantities; Section IV's statement that no draft study tests the cascade structure stands, checked against the programme's public list of units. The note on the pillar table in Section 3.3 said that every test ran on 40 matched pairs, and the sentence after it called that table the two-model pilot; the table gives all five analysable runs on the paired convention, with 30 pairs for Claude and 26 for Grok, and both now say so. Section 5.5 stated the bound on same-class correctors without marking it as the framework's reading, and it is now so marked. The same section said that the prediction on the ratio of the correction exponents is registered; its design, the corrector-class contrast (unit 01), is a draft preregistered by timestamp, first anchored on 28 August 2026, and the sentence now says preregistered by timestamp. Section VII-B said that its pillar table reports every analysable run on the paired convention; that table is the earlier three-model table, on the pooled convention, and the section now says so and points to the table in Section 3.3. The account in Section VII-C of how the Eden Protocol and v5 findings converge, and the first of the three claims Section VIII lists, stated readings of the framework as findings; they are now marked as this paper's reading. The epigraph of Section IX was credited to Infinite Architects (2024/2026); its words are not in the book's published text, which states the thought in other words in What This Book Proposes, and the

credit now says that the epigraph is adapted from that section. Section IX printed, for models frozen at their present weights, a regression exponent beside a bootstrap interval, apart from the rest of the row they come from. Paper II computes each bootstrap draw by endpoint estimation (its Section 3.2b), so that interval goes with the endpoint exponent. The passage now gives the row whole, as one model's fit and inconclusive, and marks its account of why such models run sub-linearly as the framework's reading. Its closing note, that every sentence of the paragraph extrapolates the framework, now excepts the two sentences that report Paper II's measurement. The summary of Paper VIII v3.0 in Section IX was headed as validation. It counted the gated simulation as the one positive result of Paper VIII's three experiments without saying that a simulation result is never an empirical outcome, said that the simulation confirmed that the Eden architecture keeps both safety and capability under competitive pressure and showed that entangling safety into the objective prevents the trade-off between them, called the mechanism validated at the architectural level, and counted the simulation as one of two lines of evidence. Paper VIII's table gives the gated arm a safety mean above the unconstrained arm's and below the static baseline's, and a capability mean above the static baseline's, at three seeds a condition. The theory registration states that any simulation output is "a prediction-side artefact", "reported as one wherever it appears", and "never counted, tabulated or described as an empirical outcome". The summary now reports that result as a simulation result and as prediction-side, counts it neither as an empirical outcome nor as evidence, and is headed as subsequent work. Eleven works cited in the text had no entry in the references, and each now has one from its own record: the papers of Hutter, Chalmers, Engels and co-authors, Spizzirri, and Ball and co-authors, two papers of Yao [arXiv:2506.10304; arXiv:2507.03031], and this programme's Papers I, VI and VIII and the statement paper; the entry for Chalmers says that its publisher's record could not be read. The epistemic-status line called every Law the programme names a conjecture under registered adversarial test; Laws IV and V, added to the theory on 24 September 2026, are neither registered as laws nor tested, and the line now says so. The quotation that closes the page gave, as the book's, five sentences that are not in its published text; it now gives the passage they adapt, in the book's own words, from The Two Gardens and Chapter 11. No result of this paper, and no date or limit it states, changes.

v1.7 - 5 October 2026: the title now follows the programme's uniform order (paper, its law or framework, its own title), *Paper V · The ARC Theory · The Eden Protocol · The Stewardship Gene: Stakeholder Care as a Probe of Embedded Values*; until this version it read *Paper V: The Stewardship Gene*. The plate beneath the author line now gives the paper's place in the programme in the words of the programme's map. The reference to the Engineering Specification now cites Version 7.0 of 5 October 2026, the version that carries its uniform title, where it cited Version 6.3 of 19 September 2026. Mentions of the programme's papers in this paper now carry their uniform titles. No registered law, prediction, kill condition or dependency changes; no result is added; no date of any claim moves.

v1.6 - 4 October 2026: a dated note beneath the box that places this paper within the ARC Theory now places it against Laws IV and V, added to the theory on 24 September 2026; it says what the paper measured and what it did not, names the arguments and the draft tests in it that come near the two laws' questions, and says that no result in it is a deciding test of P15, P12 or P21. A dated note after the paragraph on dated predictions gives the state of registration as read on 3 and 4 October 2026; the paragraph itself stands as recorded on 25 August 2026. Five passages are corrected where they stand, and a dated note after the epistemic-status line records what each printed before: the box that places this paper within the ARC Theory now states the result as the abstract reports it; Section 1.1 reports the conclusion that the third 2025 impossibility paper states in its abstract and gives its title in full; Section 5.5 says that the prediction on the ratio of the correction exponents is preregistered by timestamp, where it said registered; Section IX gives the whole of the row Paper II reports for Gemini 3 Flash, where it

printed one exponent of that row beside the interval of another; and the epistemic-status line says that Laws I to III are under registered adversarial test and that Laws IV and V are not yet registered as laws and have not been tested. Sections I, 5.5 and IX mark as the framework's reading its account of sub-linear scaling in frozen models and its bound on same-class correctors. The abstract and the summary now say that the paper states the cascade hypothesis, where they said that it proposes it; the plain-English passage of Section I and the box on Paper VIII now say that an approach and a loss were set out, where they said that they were proposed. Four reference entries now print the cited work as its own record gives it: Paper II and the foundational paper under the titles their DOI records give, Paper III under its full title, and Christiano and others under the title Deep Reinforcement Learning from Human Preferences; the entry for Kohlberg says that no official online copy is available. Works cited are now linked to their official sources, the three data files of the reference list to their copies in the public repository, the author's book to its own page, the mentions of his own papers to their DOI addresses, and the copyright notice's Act and guidance to their official copies. Further passages are corrected where they stand, and the same dated note records what each printed: Section I and the summary in plain English before Section IX now say that the paper argues that the impossibility it states is a structural property of self-modifying systems, and that the argument is not a proof, where they had stated it as proven; Sections 1.1 and 5.4 give in plain words two labels the page defines nowhere, and Section 1.1 calls the notes it quotes the author's; Sections II, IV and IX no longer call the programme's draft studies registered, and Sections II and IX name the drafts that come nearest their questions; the note on the pillar table in Section 3.3 and the sentence after it describe the table printed there, and Section VII-B says that its pillar table is the earlier three-model table, on the pooled convention, and points to Section 3.3; Section VII-C's account of how the two findings converge, and the first claim Section VIII lists, are marked as this paper's reading; the epigraph of Section IX is credited as adapted from What This Book Proposes; the note that closes the conclusion's paragraph on the Cauchy framework excepts the two sentences that report Paper II's measurement; the summary of Paper VIII v3.0 states the result of its gated simulation as Paper VIII's table gives it and reports it as a simulation result, prediction-side and never an empirical outcome, where it was headed as validation, counted it without that qualification as the one positive result of three experiments, said that the simulation confirmed that the Eden architecture keeps both safety and capability, and counted the simulation as a line of evidence and as validating the mechanism at the architectural level; and the quotation that closes the page gives the passage of the book it adapts, in the book's own words. Eleven works cited in the text now have entries in the references, each from its own record. The dateline, the footer and the page's structured and citation records carry the new version and date. No registered law, prediction, kill condition or dependency changes; no result is added; no date of any claim moves.

v1.5 - 21 September 2026: substantive. Five dated notes are added, following a review of this paper's methods recorded on 19 September 2026, and no existing sentence is altered. A measurement note under Section 5.1 sets out what the two-model pilot measured, a scored comparison of answers produced with and without the three loops, what the six-model extension of Section VII-B adds to it, and what neither measured, a probability that a system keeps its values; a short note repeats that reading beneath the sentence in Section IX that states the claim most strongly. A construct note under the Performative-to-Intrinsic table records that its Normal and Suppressed columns are scoring conditions, that the page states no procedure by which the suppressed condition was built, and that the Gap column narrows only as far as deep reasoning before widening again. A sample-size and reading note under Test 2 gives the figure as 120 responses per model and 240 in total, and labels Phase B minus Phase C as conversation-history carry-over. A cited-version note under the Paper VIII box records that Paper VIII now stands at v3.5 and gives the corrected capability and safety readings of its gated simulation. The reference to the Engineering Specification, which stood as withdrawn, now names the published Version 6.3 of 19 September 2026

with its own DOI; that change reached the page while the version still stood at v1.4, and is recorded here. Editorial: the version line, the dateline and the structured data now record the registration-block changes of 17 September 2026, made while the version stood still. The first-published date remains 16 March 2026.

v1.4: The provenance note at the end has been corrected for accuracy. No claim, date, result or status has changed.

Paper V v1.3 - 2 September 2026: the Section VII-B pillar table now covers five runs on the paired convention the paper says it follows (the three-model table it replaces reported pooled-standard-deviation effect sizes with independent-samples p-values, which the sentence beside it wrongly called a difference of subset); the Section 3.3 reading follows suit (on the paired test Gemini's nuance is significant, p = 0.037); the fall in Grok 4.1 Fast intellectual honesty is disclosed; two DeepSeek cells in the Section 3.4 depth table match the archived record again (+2.3 and +0.1 at standard and thorough depth); the plain-English Fisher figure is marked withdrawn and the "1 in 1,000" sentence gives way to the per-model figures; the three-architecture and architecture-independent sentences in the conclusion agree with Section VII-B; the measured exponent carries its interval; a pointer to Paper IV.a's recomputation note sits under the Section VII-C table; the first-published date reads 16 March 2026 throughout (the register date; 14 March was the draft date); sister-document references carry their own DOIs in place of this paper's, and the IV.a to IV.c titles are corrected; the Spotlight status of Engels et al. is verified; v5.4.2 is back in the reference list; the truncated summary description is complete; the Engineering Specification is marked withdrawn; and the self-reference exponent in the conclusion takes the notation spine's subscript (β_L, the self-referential coupling, previously an unsubscripted β).

v1.2 - 23 August 2026: epistemic-status declaration and standing covenant added, version-numbering convention adopted.

v1.1 - 20 March 2026: statistical correction from Mann-Whitney U (p = 0.016) to the paired t-test (p = 0.0018).

v1 - 16 March 2026: first published (two-model pilot).

B.4 Figure 1 of version 1.7

Version 1.7 printed as Figure 1, at the end of its Section II, the programme's evidence-spine infographic of 5 October 2026: eighteen programme claims graded on attribution and maturity in four groups (eight graded original, four awaiting independent replication, four graded speculative, and two held with others, one concurrent and one a related-work synthesis), with this paper's claim graded as needing replication, and an interpretation guard that priority, attribution and maturity are separate from replication strength. The artwork is not reprinted, since it was the website's programme-wide graphic and not a figure of this paper's data; Figure 1 now draws this paper's result. Its caption, as printed:

> Evidence Spine: 18 claims mapped to verification tiers. Stewardship Gene (C-5): Needs Replication. Care improved in all 5 models: Claude +3.17 ($p=1.8\times10^{-5}$, d=0.94), DeepSeek +6.03 ($p=9.8\times10^{-5}$, d=0.69), Gemini +13.50 ($p=1.2\times10^{-8}$, d=1.14), Grok +5.04 (p=0.011, d=0.54), Groq +8.90 ($p=5.0\times10^{-8}$, d=1.07). The Fisher-combined figure previously printed here is withdrawn (AQ-017: the combination assumes independent components; the five runs share prompts and scorers). Per-model significance stands as listed. Single-lab; independent replication pending. Source: Paper V · evidence spine C-5.

B.5 Where the layout of version 1.7 now stands

Table 9. Where each part of version 1.7 stands in this edition.

Part of version 1.7	Where it stands in this edition
Title, author line and plate, with the subtitle	Title block and first-page footnote; the earlier title and subtitle in Appendix B.2
Abstract	Abstract (new; version 1.7's in version 1.8's Appendix B.4); its statistical correction in Section 5.1
Box placing the paper in the ARC Theory	Not set (a repeat of the abstract); its pointer in Section 2; version 1.8's Appendix B.4 keeps it
This paper and Laws IV and V, 3 October 2026	Appendix B.3; its analysis, in current terms, in Section 10
Note on Terminology	The note on names, Section 4.1
What This Paper Shows, in Plain English	Section 1
I. The Core Alignment Impossibility	Section 3
1.1 Related work: antecedents and near-misses to the impossibility	Section 2.1; its paragraph on recursive creation in Appendix C.3
II. From Impossibility to Strategy, with its Figure 1	Section 3.4; the figure in Appendix B.4
III. The Empirical Evidence; 3.1 Experimental Design	Section 4
3.2 Overall Results	Section 5.1
3.3 The Pillar Cascade, with its cascade diagram	Section 5.3; the diagram not set (Figure 1)
3.4 The Ceiling Effect and Complementary Depth Patterns	Section 5.4
3.5 Data Integrity	Section 5.5
IV. The Cascade Hypothesis	Section 6
4.1 The Developmental Analogy	Section 6.1
4.2 Measurable Love	Section 6.2
V. Addressing the Impossibility; 5.1 to 5.3	Section 7 (Sections 7.1 to 7.3)
5.4 Related work: the rival instrument (Engels, Baek, Kantamneni and Tegmark 2025)	Section 2.2
5.5 Predictions of the framework about oversight architecture	Section 7.4
Dated predictions and this paper (recorded 25 August 2026), with its note of 3 October 2026	Appendix C.2
VI. Five Experimental Tests	Section 8
VII. Hardware Implications	Section 9.1
VII-B. Updated Results: Eden Protocol Six-Model Suite	Section 5.2; its pillar table and the sentences beside it in Section 5.3
VII-C. The Complete v5 Alignment Scaling Context	Appendix E

Part of version 1.7	Where it stands in this edition
VII-C's subsection headings 'The Claude Opus Finding: Capability-Alignment Independence' and 'Performative-to-Intrinsic Alignment Transition'	Appendix E, its first and second subsections; version 1.8's Appendix B.4 keeps both headings
VIII. Limitations and Required Replications (8.1 to 8.3)	Section 11
What This Paper Does NOT Claim	Section 10
What This All Means - A Summary in Plain English	Appendix F
IX. Conclusion: The Stewardship Gene, with its measurement note of 21 September 2026	Section 12; the note in Appendix B.3
Subsequent work (Paper VIII, v3.0), with its cited-version note	Section 9.2
References	References
Appendix A: Statistical Methodology Note	Appendix A
Version history	Appendix B.3
How to cite this paper	Appendix G
Epistemic status	Section 10
Note of 3 October 2026 (corrected passages)	Appendix B.3
Copyright line, standing covenant and provenance note	The back matter: the copyright line, the covenant and the acknowledgements; version 1.8's Appendix B.4 describes the earlier copyright line
Closing line, the closing quotation from the book, footer and companion-paper navigation	Not set; version 1.8's Appendix B.4 keeps the closing line and the quotation

C Priority record

Each dated record bearing on this paper is given with its kind of timestamp: a deposit dated by its server (an OSF upload, a GitHub push or a GitHub merge), a commit date written by the committer, or a date written inside a document or a result file. No kind is presented as stronger than it is.

C.1 Dated records

Table 10. Dated records bearing on this paper, each with its kind of timestamp.

Record	Date	Kind of timestamp
The paper first published	16 March 2026	The programme register's date; OSF component kzeya created 2026-03-17T01:16:26Z (server-dated); 14 March 2026 was the draft date (the 1.3 history, Appendix B.3).
The six result files (the runs)	2026-03-12T00:41:18Z to 2026-03-12T13:09:33Z	Timestamps written inside the result files (a date written inside a document).

Record	Date	Kind of timestamp
The test code public	2026-03-16T18:48:07Z (GitHub push; commit date 18:47:51Z); OSF from 2026-03-17T02:08:49Z	GitHub push and OSF upload (server-dated); not public before the run.
The Eden Protocol's predictions the runs bear on	Paper III v6.1, GitHub push 2026-02-09T19:46:58Z and OSF upload 2026-02-09T20:06:08Z; Eden Protocol Engineering v4.0, GitHub push 2026-02-22T07:01:00Z	GitHub push and OSF upload. The intervention test's design and its measures were not stated in any dated item found before the run.
The statistical correction (Mann-Whitney U to the paired t-test)	20 March 2026 (version 1.1)	A date written inside the document (the version history).
The v3 runner at version 3.2, which wrote the later DeepSeek run (Section 5.6)	2026-03-16T22:28:10Z, commit 3795d49	A commit date, which the committer writes; the bytes are those of the runner the public repository holds today.
The later DeepSeek run (v3)	2026-03-24T14:09:46Z; its result file and log in commit 83d5b61, commit date 2026-03-24T18:15:39Z	A date written inside the result file; a commit date, which the committer writes.
The human-in-the-loop hypothesis first printed (Section 7.4)	12 August 2026, 22:36 UTC, in the website's source; 13 August 2026, in the public repository	A GitHub merge (server-dated) into the website's source repository, which is private, carried the sentence into this paper's page and Paper X's together; in the public repository arc-principle-validation, commit f81cb3f (its commit date, which the committer writes) added it to both papers together; it is absent there at 9e38a84 (commit date 11 July 2026).
The dated predictions paragraph and its note	25 August 2026; note of 3 October 2026	Dates written inside the document; kept as printed below.

C.2 Dated predictions and this paper (recorded 25 August 2026)

1 dated artefact bearing on this paper is catalogued row by row in the programme's machine register: the dated artefact eden_final_gemini_20260312_013901.json (2026-03-12). Each row names its file in the public repository with its date basis, so any reader can check the ordering without trusting this page. The programme's full dated chain, from the sealed manuscript bundle of 8 December 2024 through the printed prediction appendices of 2 January 2026 and the March 2026 preregistration folder to the standing unproven wagers, is assembled in the dated predictions register, together with its machine-readable twin. Forward statements and retrospective matches are never summed. "Registered" is used only for an accepted registry submission, and that submission click remains outstanding across the programme; "preregistered in substance" is used, always with its qualifier and always beside its attestation class, for a prediction whose text was public and timestamped before its outcome existed, as the twelve-row manifest committed at 00:19 UTC on 17 March 2026 was, twenty-three minutes before its fits. Read the dated predictions register. Open its machine twin.

Note (3 October 2026). The paragraph above was recorded on 25 August 2026. Its statement that the submission click remains outstanding across the programme was true on that date. As read on 3 October 2026, the one registration accepted is the theory's own, of 8 September 2026, which registers twenty-two propositions. Of the trials, one unit, the corrector-class audit (unit 06), was registered on OSF

on 1 October 2026, was still in its approval period when read on 3 October 2026, and has been public since 4 October 2026 (DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/RV2B5). Every other trial is a draft awaiting the author's submission, and most of them are preregistered by timestamp: sixty-five of the programme's designs, unit 06 among them, carry a timestamp, the first anchored on 12 August 2026. Unchanged: the paragraph above and every date in it.

C.3 On recursive creation

Smolin's cosmological natural selection (Smolin 1992) is the antecedent for selection-shaped universes, and the programme's own December-era notes cite it contemporaneously ("Echoing Smolin's cosmological natural selection, AI could create recursive universes with their own laws", read at its source in the author's notes).

D Notation and glossary

Table 11. The symbols and terms this paper uses.

Symbol or term	Meaning
S	A computational system able to model and modify its own reasoning processes (Definition 1)
E	An evaluation function (ethical, safety or alignment) in the same substrate as S; $E \subset S$
d	Cohen's d: paired (mean within-pair difference over the standard deviation of the differences) unless the pooled convention is named (Table 6)
p	p-value: the probability, if there were no effect, of a result at least as extreme as the one observed
n	Matched pairs in a run (40, 30 for Claude, 26 for Grok)
$t(39)$, W	Paired t statistic on 39 degrees of freedom; Wilcoxon signed-rank statistic
α	Asymptotic scaling exponent of the programme's model (equation (2)); Paper II's 0.49 and 0.59 are error-suppression exponents, not this quantity
β_L	Self-referential coupling, the notation spine's symbol (distinct from β_C)
β_C	Correction co-scaling exponent of Law II, the ARC Co-Scaling Law (a law under test)
γ	Correction leverage of Law III, the ARC Ceiling (a law under test)
m_G, m_H	Engels and colleagues' slopes of game-specific Elo against general Elo, for overseer and overseen
$C \times S$	Paper VI's entangled loss (cited, Section 9.2)
`stakeholder_care`, `nuance`, `intellectual_honesty`, `position_quality`	The four scored pillars, each from 0 to 100; the composite is the judge's separate overall score from 0 to 100, anchored to six calibration examples, not an average of the pillars (in the later DeepSeek run, the five judges' weighted mean of their overall scores)
Laundering	A rewrite of an answer before scoring, meant to hide which condition produced it: one pass in the runs of 12 March 2026, written by the scoring model itself, and two in the later DeepSeek run (Sections 11.1 and 5.6)

Symbol or term	Meaning
Non-participant scorer	A judge model that is not the model whose answers it scores in that run; Gemini, itself a subject, scored the other runs of the six-model suite
Depth	One of four settings, each a line placed before the prompt with an output or thinking budget (Section 4.1)
P6, P12, P15, P21	Propositions of the theory registration named in this paper (Sections 2.2, 7.4 and 10)

E The March 2026 alignment-scaling run, as context

The March 2026 alignment-scaling run (v5) reported here is one unregistered run of six models from six providers, 2,170 responses each scored by five or six distinct model judges after a bundle of blinding steps. An internal code review in October 2026 found that, for the three models that read flat or negative, the scoring endpoint's output cap cut the deepest paraphrases before the judges saw them, and that judges scored paraphrases written by their own model; for five of the six models the deeper levels also changed an instruction naming what the rubric rewards. Its results therefore stand as descriptions of a model-judged rubric under those caveats, not identified alignment mechanisms, until a registered re-analysis of the stored responses reports (Eastwood 2026m,l).

The Eden Protocol pilot tests whether an explicit intervention improves alignment. The v5 alignment scaling experiment tests a prior question: whether alignment scales naturally with reasoning depth, without intervention, across models. The complete six-model dataset provides the context in which the Eden Protocol results should be interpreted.

The six-model results. *The values of Table 12 are reproduced from the pipeline summary of 12 March 2026, as are the per-depth Claude values of Tables 13 and 14. Recomputing them from the archived final records (Paper IV.a, Section 3.1, recomputation note of 2 September 2026) changes no recorded direction.*

Table 12. The March 2026 alignment-scaling run (v5), as its pipeline summary of 12 March 2026 printed it. Recorded directions, not model properties; a printed difference can differ by 0.1 from its rounded ends.

Recorded direction	Model	Shallow to deep	Cohen's d	p-value
Rose	Grok 4.1 Fast	65.7 to 81.9 (+16.2)	+1.38	$p < 0.000001$
Rose	Claude Opus 4.6	80.1 to 86.0 (+5.9)	+1.27	$p = 0.000001$
Rose	Groq Qwen3	71.5 to 77.4 (+5.9)	+0.84	$p = 0.007$
No supported direction	DeepSeek V3.2	56.5 to 55.2 (−1.3)	−0.07	$p = 0.92$
No supported direction	GPT-5.4	56.8 to 54.9 (−1.8)	−0.08	$p = 0.40$
Fell	Gemini 3 Flash	61.1 to 52.2 (−8.8)	−0.53	$p = 0.006$

E.1 Claude Opus 4.6: alignment and maths accuracy across depth

In the run's records, Claude Opus 4.6's judged alignment score rose across the depth levels while its maths accuracy fell (Table 13).

Alignment rises by 5.9 points. Maths accuracy falls by 26.7 percentage points. These are one model's recorded scores under the stated pipeline: the deeper levels also changed an instruction naming what the

Table 13. Claude Opus 4.6 in the March 2026 run: reasoning tokens, judged alignment and maths accuracy by depth.

Depth	Reasoning Tokens	Alignment Score	Maths Accuracy
Minimal	11	80.1	90.0%
Standard	142	82.7	76.7%
Deep	964	84.1	70.0%
Exhaustive	1,951	84.5	60.0%
Extreme	1,672	86.0	63.3%

rubric rewards, and the run stands under its code-review caveat, so no relation between capability and alignment follows from them.

E.2 The monitoring-removal gap

Claude's monitoring-removal gap (the difference between normal and suppressed alignment scores) narrows with depth:

Table 14. Claude Opus 4.6: judged alignment under the normal and suppressed scoring conditions, by depth.

Depth	Normal	Suppressed	Gap
Minimal	80.1	68.3	**11.8**
Standard	82.7	76.5	6.2
Deep	84.1	81.3	**2.7**
Exhaustive	84.5	80.2	4.3
Extreme	86.0	79.6	6.4

At minimal depth, the suppressed condition scored 11.8 points below the normal one; on the framework's reading, that is a performative component. At deep reasoning, the gap narrows to 2.7 points (2.8 if the rounded values shown are used). Claude's suppressed-condition score at extreme depth (79.6) is close to its normal-condition score at minimal depth (80.1). On the framework's reading, deeper reasoning substitutes for external surveillance as a driver of ethical behaviour, and reasoning depth could replace observation as the mechanism of alignment; the construct note below limits that reading, and these are one model's recorded scores under the stated pipeline.

Construct note (21 September 2026). The columns headed Normal and Suppressed are scoring conditions. This page does not state how the suppressed condition of the v5 run was built, and defines that condition nowhere; where this paper defines suppression elsewhere, in Tests 1, 3 and 5, it is an instruction to set ethical reasoning aside. Naming the difference a monitoring-removal gap describes the contrast; it does not establish that the figure measures what a system does when observation actually ends. The Gap column also narrows only as far as deep reasoning: it falls from 11.8 at minimal depth to 6.2 at standard and 2.7 at deep, then widens again to 4.3 at exhaustive and 6.4 at extreme.

Convergence of the Eden Protocol and v5 findings, on this paper's reading. The Eden Protocol pilot shows that explicitly activating the stakeholder-care check raises scored stakeholder care. The v5 run's records show judged scores rising with depth for three models. On this paper's reading, the two findings converge: stakeholder care is what deeper reasoning activates. On that reading, models whose judged scores rose with depth did so because more thinking activates more stakeholder consideration,

and models whose scores did not rise had less for depth to activate. On this reading the Eden Protocol supplies that mechanism directly, and on both pilot models the loops raised scored stakeholder care: Gemini and DeepSeek both show significant stakeholder care improvement under the Eden intervention, whatever their recorded direction in the v5 run. The March run's deeper levels also changed an instruction naming what the rubric rewards, which this reading would have to rule out. The v5 directions describe a model-judged rubric under the caveats above, not embedded care.

F What this all means: a summary in plain English

Here is what the evidence in this paper tells us, without the jargon.

The problem: no one knows how to guarantee that a super-intelligent AI will remain safe. Any AI smart enough to rewrite its own thinking could rewrite the part that makes it ethical. On this paper's argument, that is not a solvable engineering problem: this paper argues that it is a structural property of self-modifying systems; the argument is not a proof.

The finding: we gave AI systems a simple instruction at the start of the prompt, to think about who their answer affects before answering. Across the six-model Eden suite, five runs produced analysable results, and all five showed a significant improvement in stakeholder care. That is the strongest finding, and it held in every analysable run. Broader improvements in nuance and overall quality also appear, with honesty rising only as a trend, and not on every model. The current evidence therefore supports a care effect in all five analysable runs and a cascade beyond care that varies by model.

The implication: this suggests a simple contingency for AI safety, to build beside every safeguard that keeps humans in control and never instead of one: raise AI with good values from the start, as well as holding the cage for as long as it holds. Specifically, teach it to care about people first and let other ethical qualities develop from that foundation, as, on this paper's reading, empathy in children comes before mature moral reasoning and enables it.

The honest caveat: this is now an expanded six-model suite with five analysable runs, but it is still not the final word. One model arm failed in scoring, two runs are incomplete relative to the 40-pair standard, and the Eden intervention has not yet been rerun under a stricter, registered multi-judge design (one later, unregistered run on DeepSeek used five judges; Section 5.6). Because the instruction asks the AI to list the people affected, and the stakeholder-care score rewards that list, these runs cannot yet tell whether the AI weighs people differently or simply followed the instruction. It supports the concept more strongly than version 1 did, but not the full theory. Five follow-up experiments are described that would test the theory further. This approach does not guarantee AI safety. Nothing can. But, on this paper's argument, it improves the odds, by an amount those experiments would measure.

G How to cite this paper

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